



THE ROMAN SENATE AND THE EMPERORS

Institutions, Elections, Power, Civil War, and Imperial Rule

From the city's legendary kings to the deposition of Romulus Augustulus,
with the Eastern Roman continuation

A CHRONOLOGICAL REFERENCE HISTORY

Scope and Method

This book explains the Roman Senate as an institution rather than as a modern legislature. In the Republic, the Senate did not normally pass statutes, elect magistrates, or embody equal popular representation. It guided magistrates, controlled many public resources, assigned provinces, received embassies, supervised religion and diplomacy, and gave durable continuity to a state whose elected officers usually served for only one year. Its decrees were formally advisory but could be politically commanding.

The emperor list follows the conventional history of ancient Roman imperial rule from Augustus in 27 BCE through the end of the Western imperial office in 476 CE. It includes recognized co-emperors and the Eastern emperors whose policies directly shaped the late Western Empire. Brief sections distinguish major usurpers and breakaway regimes. Because the Roman Empire continued from Constantinople for nearly another millennium, a final overview follows the Eastern Roman succession to 1453 rather than implying that Rome itself ended in 476.

Ancient evidence is uneven. Speeches in historians are often literary reconstructions; hostile senatorial writers may exaggerate vice or madness; imperial inscriptions present official self-portraits; coinage and law codes tell us what rulers wished to proclaim; and later biographies sometimes preserve rumor beside fact. Profiles therefore separate secure policies and events from allegations, disputed motives, and hostile tradition.

A note on dates

Dates before the Common Era are written BCE; dates after it are written CE. Reign dates are inclusive and sometimes approximate when an emperor was proclaimed, recognized, deposed, and killed on different dates in different parts of the Empire.

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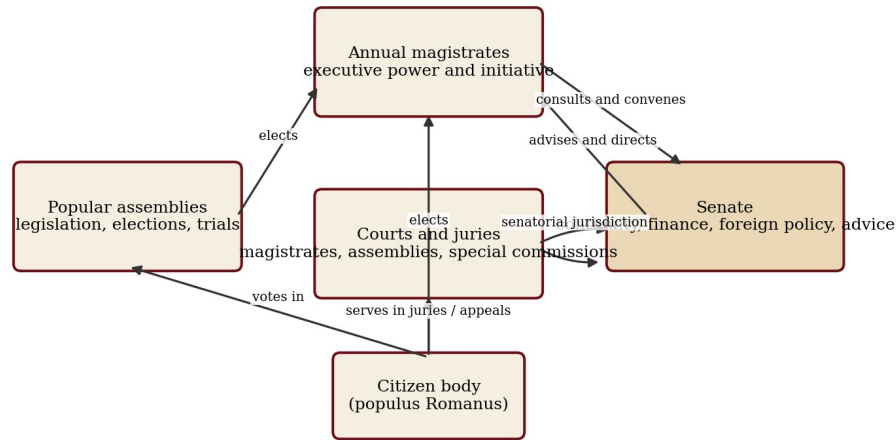
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The Constitutional Problem in One View

The Roman Republican Constitution: Overlapping Authority, Not Separate Branches

Formal sovereignty rested with the people; practical direction often rested with the Senate.



The Roman Republic was a negotiated system of magistrates, Senate, popular assemblies, law, custom, and public pressure - not a clean separation of powers.

Roman government depended on overlapping legitimacy. Magistrates possessed imperium or other legally defined powers; citizens voted in assemblies; the Senate supplied continuity and elite consensus; tribunes defended plebeian rights and could veto; priests interpreted sacred obligations; and custom - mos maiorum, the “way of the ancestors” - constrained conduct that law did not fully specify. The Republic endured when these elements accepted mutual limits. It failed when commanders, assemblies, tribunes, juries, and the Senate became weapons in winner-take-all struggles backed by armies.

CHAPTER 1

Before the Republic: Kings, Fathers, and the Council of Elders

The uncertain origins of Rome's most durable political institution

Roman tradition placed a council of leading men beside the kings from the city's foundation. The word *senatus* was connected with *senex*, "old man," and later Romans imagined the first senators as *patres*, the "fathers" of the community. The historical details are obscured by legend: the literary narratives were written centuries after the supposed reigns of Romulus, Numa, Servius Tullius, and Tarquinius Superbus. Yet the broad pattern is plausible. Early Italian communities commonly relied on councils of clan leaders, priests, warriors, and wealthy household heads to advise kings, witness treaties, transmit custom, and manage succession.

Livy and Dionysius of Halicarnassus describe Romulus selecting one hundred fathers, later enlarged as the city absorbed new groups. These exact numbers are not secure evidence for the eighth century BCE. They tell us more about how republican Romans understood authority: legitimate government joined a chief magistrate, a council of leading families, and the organized people. The Senate's prestige therefore rested on an origin story older than the Republic itself.

Under the kings, the Senate was not sovereign. A king led armies, judged disputes, represented the community before the gods, and summoned councils. The Senate advised him and may have played a role during an interregnum, when no king was in office. Later republican procedure preserved this idea through the *interrex*, a patrician senator appointed for a brief period to arrange elections when ordinary magistrates could not do so.

The expulsion of the last king, conventionally dated to 509 BCE, was remembered as a moral and constitutional revolution. Annual magistrates replaced life tenure; two consuls replaced one king; appeal and collegiality limited coercion; and aristocratic councils claimed guardianship of liberty. The story was polished by later generations, but it captured the Republic's foundational fear: power held by one man for too long could become kingship, and kingship could become tyranny.

Legend and evidence

The regal period cannot be reconstructed as confidently as the middle and late Republic. Archaeology confirms urban growth, elite display, trade, temples, and strong Etruscan influence, but not the detailed speeches and constitutional reforms attributed to individual kings.

"The state is the people's affair." — Cicero, *On the Republic*, in a compact definition of *res publica*

Sources and further reading: Livy, Book 1; Dionysius of Halicarnassus, *Roman Antiquities*; Cicero, *On the Republic*; T. J. Cornell, *The Beginnings of Rome*; Gary Forsythe, *A Critical History of Early Rome*.

CHAPTER 2

The Republican Constitution

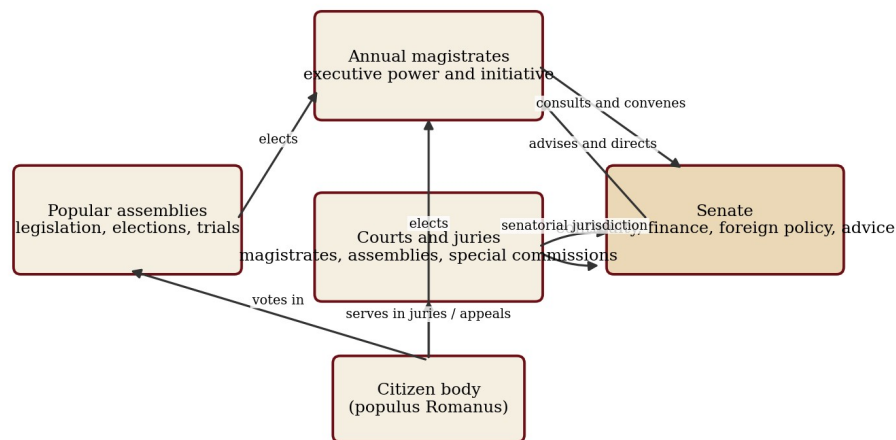
A mixed system of magistrates, Senate, assemblies, tribunes, priests, and unwritten restraints

The Roman Republic had no single written constitution. Its rules came from statutes, religious law, precedents, oaths, senatorial decrees, decisions of magistrates, and custom. Offices accumulated over centuries. New institutions were often added during crises without abolishing older ones. The result was not tidy, but it was adaptable: several bodies could claim a legitimate share in public decision-making.

The Greek historian Polybius, writing in the second century BCE, famously interpreted Rome as a “mixed constitution.” The consuls resembled monarchy because they commanded armies and executed policy; the Senate resembled aristocracy because it controlled finance and diplomacy; the popular assemblies resembled democracy because citizens elected magistrates and enacted laws. His model captured the interdependence of Roman institutions, though it understated inequality and the informal dominance of wealthy families.

The Roman Republican Constitution: Overlapping Authority, Not Separate Branches

Formal sovereignty rested with the people; practical direction often rested with the Senate.



No institution governed alone. Roman politics worked through overlapping authority, negotiated precedent, and the threat of veto or public resistance.

The magistrates

Magistrates were elected officeholders whose powers varied by rank. Consuls and praetors held imperium, the authority to command armies, convene the Senate and assemblies, and exercise coercive jurisdiction within legal limits. Censors conducted the census, reviewed the Senate, supervised public morals, and contracted some public works and revenues. Aediles oversaw markets, urban order, grain, and games. Quaestors handled finances and assisted commanders. Tribunes of the plebs possessed sacrosanctity, could aid citizens, summon the plebeian assembly, propose measures, and veto many official acts.

Three devices restrained officeholders. Annuality meant most offices lasted one year. Collegiality meant two or more people usually held the same office, allowing one colleague to obstruct another. Accountability meant magistrates could face prosecution after leaving office. These restraints worked best when politicians accepted that today’s defeated rival might be tomorrow’s colleague. Civil war began when force, extraordinary commands, and personal armies overwhelmed rotation and restraint.

The Senate

The Senate was a continuing council in a system of short-term offices. Its members brought experience from magistracies, family networks, provincial commands, priesthoods, courts, and military service. It debated policy and issued *senatus consulta*, formal resolutions recorded by clerks. In strict theory, these were advice to magistrates. In practice, a united Senate could define legitimate action, release funds, assign responsibilities, receive foreign envoys, and make refusal politically perilous.

The people and their assemblies

Roman citizens did not vote as one undifferentiated mass. They voted in units - centuries or tribes - and each unit cast one collective vote. The presiding magistrate set the question; assemblies could accept or reject it but did not freely amend the proposal on the floor. Wealth, residence, patronage, turnout, and the order in which units voted shaped outcomes. Popular sovereignty was genuine, but it operated through institutions that magnified organization and status.

Law, religion, and custom

Public action required religious correctness. Magistrates took auspices; priests guarded calendars and ritual knowledge; unfavorable signs could suspend meetings; and vows accompanied war and elections. Religion did not sit outside politics. It supplied a language of legitimacy and a procedural system that could both restrain rash action and be manipulated for partisan purposes. Above law stood no written constitutional court. Romans instead appealed to precedent, ancestral custom, the people, tribunician protection, and eventually force.

Sources and further reading: Polybius, *Histories* 6; Cicero, *On the Republic* and *On the Laws*; Andrew Lintott, *The Constitution of the Roman Republic*; Harriet Flower, *Roman Republics*; Fergus Millar, *The Crowd in Rome in the Late Republic*.

CHAPTER 3

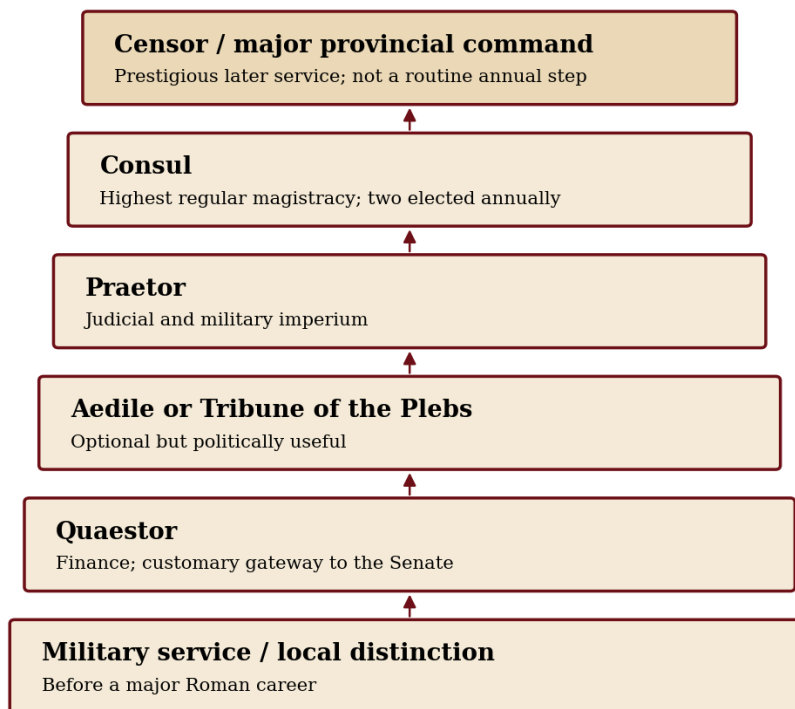
Who Became a Senator?

Census, ancestry, election to office, censorial review, and the cursus honorum

For much of the Republic, citizens did not directly elect senators. They elected magistrates, and service in qualifying offices normally opened the way into the Senate. Censors periodically revised the roll, adding men who met the expectations of rank and removing those judged financially, legally, or morally unfit. By the late Republic, Sulla's reforms regularized entry after the quaestorship and expanded the body to roughly six hundred. Augustus later reduced and repeatedly reviewed imperial membership.

The Senate began as a patrician stronghold but did not remain one. The long Conflict of the Orders opened magistracies and priesthoods to plebeians. A new nobility emerged from families that had reached the consulship, whether patrician or plebeian. The Latin term *novus homo*, "new man," described someone such as Cicero who reached the consulship without a consular ancestor. Such advancement was possible, but exceptional: elections demanded reputation, money, alliances, and public visibility.

A Typical Late-Republican Cursus Honorum



Age rules and intervals varied over time; wealth, ancestry, patronage, military reputation, and public speaking all mattered.

The typical late-republican sequence of offices. Exact age rules and prerequisites changed, and extraordinary careers were common in crisis.

Property, dignity, and public service

Senatorial rank assumed wealth because officeholding was unpaid, campaigns were expensive, and elite competition required hospitality, buildings, games, legal advocacy, and patronage. Senators were expected to derive status from land rather than retail trade, although real fortunes could involve credit, tax contracts, shipping through associates, provincial exploitation, and inheritance. The senatorial census threshold under the Empire was conventionally one million sesterces, four times the equestrian threshold.

Rank carried obligations. Senators were expected to attend meetings, serve as governors and commanders, advise magistrates, finance public display, maintain the honor of their household, and avoid occupations deemed degrading. The censor's moral jurisdiction reflected a central Roman idea: public trust depended not only on legal qualifications but on dignitas, reputation, and conduct appropriate to one's station.

The cursus honorum

Office or stage	Typical role
Military tribune / preliminary service	Military experience, staff work, and social introduction often preceded major office. Requirements varied by period.
Quaestor	Financial administration in Rome, Italy, or a province; in the late Republic, election normally led to Senate membership.
Aedile or tribune of the plebs	Not always required. Aediles gained visibility through markets and games; tribunes could legislate, veto, and mobilize the plebeian assembly.
Praetor	Held imperium, presided over courts, and often governed a province after the year of office.
Consul	The highest regular magistracy; two consuls gave their names to the year, led the state, and received major commands.
Censor	Usually a former consul. Conducted the census, reviewed status, and exercised exceptional moral prestige.

The lex Villia annalis of 180 BCE is associated with minimum ages and intervals between offices, though its precise rules are debated. By Cicero's day the ideal minimums were approximately thirty for quaestor, thirty-six for aedile, thirty-nine for praetor, and forty-two for consul. Patricians and extraordinary commands complicated the pattern. The cursus was both a training ladder and a competition for scarce honor.

Women, freedpeople, provincials, and exclusion

Senatorial office was restricted to freeborn male citizens. Women could not vote or hold magistracies, yet aristocratic women influenced marriage alliances, household wealth, religious life, petitions, succession, and patronage. Freedpeople were excluded from the Senate, but imperial freedmen sometimes wielded enormous administrative power. As citizenship spread and the Empire integrated provincial elites, senators increasingly came from Italy, Spain, Gaul, North Africa, the Greek East, and other regions. Claudius' support for admitting leading men from Gallia Comata was controversial precisely because the Senate defined Roman status.

Sources and further reading: Cicero, *For Murena* and letters; Livy; Suetonius, *Augustus and Claudius*; Lily Ross Taylor, *Roman Voting Assemblies*; T. P. Wiseman, *New Men in the Roman Senate*; Richard Talbert, *The Senate of Imperial Rome*.

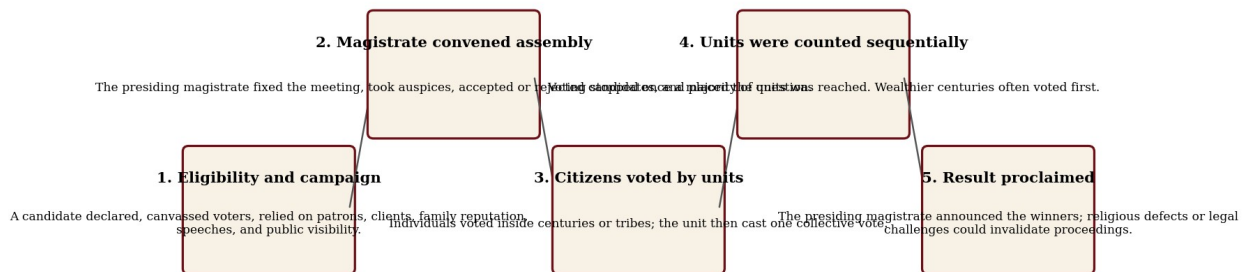
CHAPTER 4

Elections and Assemblies

How Roman citizens voted, who controlled the ballot, and why wealth mattered

Roman elections were public rituals of competition. Candidates canvassed in a whitened toga, sought endorsements, displayed family achievements, greeted citizens by name, and cultivated associations, neighborhoods, veterans, clients, and local elites. Bribery laws reveal the prevalence of gifts, banquets, promised favors, and organized electoral agents. A successful campaign joined personal reputation, inherited prestige, military achievement, legal advocacy, generosity, and coalition building.

How a Republican Election Worked



Roman elections were competitive, but not equal-vote elections in the modern sense. Geography, wealth, order of voting, patronage, and control of procedure shaped outcomes.

A simplified election sequence. The presiding magistrate controlled procedure, while citizens voted by organized units rather than by a national popular total.

The comitia centuriata

The Centuriate Assembly elected consuls, praetors, and censors; declared war in important cases; and heard certain capital appeals. Citizens voted in centuries originally connected with military and property classification. The system was reorganized over time, but wealthier centuries retained structural advantages and often voted earlier. Once a majority of centuries had declared, voting stopped, so later and poorer units might never vote.

The comitia tributa and concilium plebis

The Tribal Assembly elected quaestors and curule aediles and passed legislation. The Plebeian Council, organized by the same thirty-five tribes but excluding patricians, elected tribunes and plebeian aediles and adopted plebiscites. After the lex Hortensia of 287 BCE, plebiscites bound the whole citizen body without separate senatorial authorization. Tribes were territorial units, but population was uneven: a crowded urban tribe still cast only one vote, while rural tribes could be dominated by landowners and municipal networks.

The mechanics of a vote

1. A qualified magistrate announced and summoned the assembly, usually after required notice and religious preliminaries.

2. Candidates or proponents spoke in preliminary meetings, while supporters canvassed and organized turnout.
3. Citizens entered voting enclosures by tribe or century. Secret written ballots, introduced by laws of the second century BCE, reduced but did not eliminate elite pressure.
4. Each voting unit's internal majority determined its single unit vote. The assembly's result depended on a majority of units, not a majority of individual ballots across Rome.
5. The presiding magistrate announced the result. Religious objections, violence, vetoes, or procedural disputes could delay or invalidate proceedings.

Representation without equality

Rome's citizen body expanded across Italy and eventually the Mediterranean, but voting remained concentrated in the city of Rome. Citizens who lived far away had to travel at their own expense. No absentee ballot or representative chamber translated provincial or Italian population into regular legislative seats. This made organized urban crowds, nearby landowners, clients, veterans, and elites capable of financing travel disproportionately influential.

Roman elections were neither modern democracy nor mere theater. Competition was real, outcomes could surprise aristocratic managers, and legislation could overturn senatorial preferences. Yet the system privileged wealth, social organization, public reputation, and the magistrate who framed the question. The assemblies embodied the legal sovereignty of the Roman people while rarely producing political equality.

Did the Senate elect the consuls?

No. Citizens in the Centuriate Assembly elected consuls. The Senate could shape the field through prestige, endorsements, decrees, and control of assignments, but it did not cast the formal electoral vote as a chamber.

Sources and further reading: Cicero, *Handbook of Electioneering* (traditionally attributed to Quintus Cicero), *For Murena*, and letters; Polybius 6; Lily Ross Taylor, *Roman Voting Assemblies*; Alexander Yakobson, *Elections and Electioneering in Rome*; Fergus Millar, *The Crowd in Rome*.

CHAPTER 5

How the Senate Met and Decided

Summons, order of speaking, debate, decrees, filibuster, and the politics of consensus

The Senate could not ordinarily convene itself. A magistrate with the right to consult it - especially a consul, praetor, or tribune - summoned a meeting and set the question. Meetings took place in consecrated spaces, most famously the Curia in the Forum, but also in temples when religion, security, or ceremony required. A quorum was sometimes specified for particular business, though attendance varied with season, war, and political urgency.

The order of debate

The presiding magistrate opened business, reported documents or dispatches, and asked senators for their opinions. Rank shaped the order of speaking. In the late Republic the *princeps senatus*, a prestigious senior member selected by the censors, might be consulted first; consulars preceded praetorians and junior senators. Under the Empire the emperor's presence, written speech, or known preference could dominate the room, but senators still competed over wording, honors, legal interpretation, and blame.

A senator's *sententia* was more than a yes-or-no vote. He could propose an alternative, combine issues, praise a previous speaker, or recommend a detailed course. Debate might continue until dusk. Because official public business could not proceed after sunset, prolonged speeches and procedural obstruction functioned as a filibuster. Presiding magistrates could divide complex motions, call for voting, or refuse to put an unwelcome proposal.

Voting and the *senatus consultum*

The Senate often voted by physical division: members moved to support one opinion or another. The winning view became a *senatus consultum* if no veto or legal obstacle intervened. Clerks recorded the text, witnesses authenticated it, and copies could be deposited in official archives or published. A tribunician veto could reduce a resolution to an *auctoritas senatus* - an expression of senatorial opinion without full formal force - while preserving its political message.

Consensus and pressure

Roman elite culture valued apparent consensus. A unanimous or overwhelming decree strengthened a magistrate, reassured allies, and signaled that opposition stood outside respectable politics. Yet consensus could conceal intimidation. Armed men might surround the meeting place; a dominant commander's wishes might be known; prosecutions or confiscations could silence speakers; and under emperors, accusations of treason made dissent dangerous. The theatrical language of free debate therefore survived in settings of very unequal power.

Records and what we can know

Most senatorial records are lost. We reconstruct procedure from laws, inscriptions, papyri, letters, legal compilations, and narratives by Cicero, Tacitus, Cassius Dio, and others. Cicero's correspondence offers an unusually immediate view of lobbying, attendance, drafting, and rumor. Tacitus uses Senate scenes as moral drama, contrasting servility and courage. His speeches illuminate elite anxieties but should not be read as stenographic transcripts.

"They rushed into slavery." — Tacitus, *Annals* 1, characterizing senatorial behavior under Tiberius

Sources and further reading: Cicero's speeches and correspondence; Tacitus, *Annals*; Cassius Dio; Richard Talbert, *The Senate of Imperial Rome*; Andrew Lintott, *Constitution of the Roman Republic*.

CHAPTER 6

What Powers Did the Senate Possess?

Finance, foreign affairs, provinces, war, religion, legislation, justice, and emergencies

The Senate's authority did not fit one legal category. Some functions depended on inherited practice, some on control of resources, some on magistrates' willingness to obey, and some on later statutes. Its power was greatest when it acted collectively and commanders accepted its allocation of money, provinces, triumphs, and status. It was weakest when a popular assembly, tribune, victorious general, or emperor could bypass it.

Finance and the treasury

The Senate supervised the aerarium, the public treasury traditionally housed in the Temple of Saturn. It authorized many extraordinary expenditures, indemnities, provincial budgets, and payments to commanders. Quaestors administered accounts, but senatorial decrees directed major uses. Control was never absolute: assemblies could legislate distributions; generals controlled booty; tax contractors handled revenues; and emperors later developed the fiscus and other funds under imperial management.

Foreign affairs and diplomacy

Foreign envoys appeared before the Senate to seek alliances, arbitration, aid, recognition, or relief. The Senate dispatched commissions, received reports, framed treaty terms, and decided how conquered or allied communities would be treated. In the middle Republic this diplomatic centrality made the Curia the nerve center of a Mediterranean alliance system. Formal treaty ratification could involve the people, but the Senate managed the continuous work of negotiation.

War, armies, and provinces

Consuls commanded armies by virtue of imperium, yet the Senate influenced strategy by allocating troops, funds, supplies, and provincial theaters. It could prorogue a commander's imperium as proconsul or propraetor, allowing campaigns beyond the annual term. After provincial empire expanded, the Senate assigned provinces and heard reports. Popular laws increasingly granted extraordinary commands directly, as with Pompey, weakening senatorial control and personalizing military loyalty.

Religion

The Senate ordered consultations of priestly colleges, accepted or rejected foreign cults, decreed public thanksgivings, supervised vows and prodigies, and linked victory to divine favor. The suppression of the Bacchanalia in 186 BCE, known from an inscription, shows the Senate coordinating investigation across Italy. Religious policy was simultaneously sacred, social, and political: unauthorized associations could appear as threats to hierarchy and public order.

Law and legislation

During the Republic, laws were enacted by assemblies, not by the Senate alone. Nevertheless, the Senate discussed proposed laws, instructed magistrates, interpreted implementation, and exerted auctoritas. Under the Principate, popular assemblies withered and senatus consulta came to function as legislation, though often at imperial initiative. By late antiquity, imperial constitutions - edicts, rescripts, mandates, and decrees - were the primary source of new law.

Justice

The Senate conducted investigations, advised on public crimes, assigned special commissions, and under the Empire sat as a high court in cases involving senators, treason, extortion, or provincial complaints. Judicial business enhanced its prestige

but also exposed it to imperial manipulation. A prosecution could punish corruption or remove a political rival; a trial for *maiestas*, injured majesty, could transform criticism into treason.

Emergency measures

The *senatus consultum ultimum*, the “final decree,” urged magistrates to see that the state suffered no harm. It did not formally suspend law or create a modern state of emergency. Its meaning was contested because magistrates used it to justify lethal force against citizens, most famously during the death of Gaius Gracchus and the suppression of Catiline’s associates. Supporters called it necessary defense; critics saw an evasion of appeal and due process.

Category	Meaning
Strong practical control	Diplomatic reception, provincial assignments, many expenditures, religious consultations, honors, triumphs, and continuity of policy.
Shared or contested authority	War declarations, legislation, criminal jurisdiction, land distributions, citizenship, extraordinary commands, and emergency force.
Not normally a senatorial power	Direct election of magistrates, routine command of armies as a corporate body, or unilateral enactment of republican statutes.

Sources and further reading: Polybius 6; Livy, including the Bacchanalian crisis; Cicero, *On the Laws* and political speeches; *Senatus Consultum de Bacchanalibus* inscription; Andrew Lintott; Erich Gruen, *The Last Generation of the Roman Republic*.

CHAPTER 7

The Conflict of the Orders

Patricians, plebeians, tribunes, written law, and the broadening of the governing class

Roman tradition described the early Republic as a struggle between patricians, who monopolized leading offices and religious authority, and plebeians, the rest of the citizen body organized through their own tribunes and council. The narrative is schematic and later writers compressed centuries of disputes into exemplary episodes. Still, the institutional outcome is clear: plebeian organization created durable checks on magistrates and opened the highest offices to a wider elite.

Secession and the tribunate

The first plebeian secession, traditionally dated to 494 BCE, was a collective withdrawal of labor and military service. The resulting tribunes of the plebs were declared sacrosanct, making physical interference a religious offense. Their power of *auxilium* allowed them to aid citizens; *intercessio* allowed veto; and their capacity to summon the plebs gave them a legislative platform. The tribunate could defend ordinary citizens, but ambitious nobles also used it to advance programs and attack rivals.

The Twelve Tables

The Twelve Tables, traditionally produced in 451-450 BCE, publicly stated rules concerning procedure, debt, family authority, property, injury, and religion. The text survives only in fragments quoted by later authors. Its importance lay not in equality - many rules were harsh - but in the claim that citizens could know the law rather than depend entirely on elite memory and priestly interpretation.

Opening the offices

The Licinio-Sextian reforms of the fourth century BCE are traditionally associated with plebeian access to the consulship. Over time plebeians entered censorships, praetorships, major priesthoods, and the Senate. The *lex Hortensia* made plebiscites binding on all citizens. These victories did not create social equality. They fused leading plebeian families with patricians into a competitive nobility whose authority rested on officeholding and ancestral achievement.

The constitutional settlement expanded participation while preserving hierarchy. Tribunes and assemblies gave the people institutional leverage. At the same time, wealthy plebeians gained the greatest access to senatorial careers. Later reformers such as the Gracchi could invoke plebeian sovereignty against the Senate, but they were themselves aristocrats using institutions created by an earlier struggle.

Why this mattered for the Senate

The Senate became less a patrician caste and more an officeholding aristocracy. Its resilience came partly from absorbing successful challengers rather than excluding them forever.

Sources and further reading: Livy, Books 2-10; Dionysius of Halicarnassus; fragments of the Twelve Tables; T. J. Cornell; Kurt Raaflaub, *Social Struggles in Archaic Rome*; Harriet Flower.

CHAPTER 8

Empire Before Emperors

Conquest, provincial government, wealth, slavery, and the strain on republican politics

Rome acquired an empire while retaining institutions designed for a city-state. Victory over Carthage, the Hellenistic kingdoms, and numerous regional powers brought provinces, tribute, mines, land, slaves, and military commitments. The Senate coordinated this expansion more successfully than any single magistrate could, but expansion changed the conditions under which senatorial government operated.

Provincial commands and temptation

A governor combined military command, jurisdiction, taxation oversight, and diplomatic authority far from Rome. He was expected to protect allies and uphold Roman dignity, yet his term offered opportunities for extortion, gifts, requisitions, and patronage. Provincial communities could prosecute former governors in extortion courts, but elite juries and political alliances affected accountability. Cicero's prosecution of Verres dramatized both abuse and the possibility of legal redress.

Army and land

Long wars burdened small farmers and created demands for land, debt relief, and colonial settlement. Ancient authors linked the decline of an independent peasantry to large estates worked by slaves, though modern scholarship emphasizes regional variation. What is certain is that military service, veteran settlement, Italian landholding, and citizenship became explosive political issues. Commanders who secured land and rewards for soldiers acquired personal loyalty.

Public contracts and equestrians

Tax collection, mining, supply, and construction could be contracted to companies associated with wealthy equestrians. Senators were legally and socially distinguished from the equestrian order, but interests overlapped through relatives, creditors, and clients. Disputes over provincial taxation and jury composition became conflicts between elite groups rather than simple contests between rich and poor.

Culture and scale

Conquest brought Greek art, philosophy, rhetoric, physicians, teachers, and literary models. Some senators embraced Greek learning; others warned that luxury and foreign customs weakened ancestral discipline. Behind the moral debate lay a material transformation: aristocrats now competed with wealth from several continents, and successful generals returned with triumphs, armies, captives, and a public stature difficult for ordinary institutions to contain.

The Senate's strength - a narrow class of experienced rivals who shared norms - became a vulnerability. Competition for commands and honors intensified. Obstruction could leave urgent grievances unresolved, while bypassing obstruction through popular laws and personal armies further weakened trust. The Republic did not collapse merely because Rome became large, but empire multiplied the rewards of controlling the state and the resources available to those willing to break precedent.

Sources and further reading: Polybius; Livy; Cicero, *Against Verres*; Sallust, *Jugurthine War*; William Harris, *War and Imperialism in Republican Rome*; Keith Hopkins, *Conquerors and Slaves*; Erich Gruen, *The Hellenistic World and the Coming of Rome*.

CHAPTER 9

The Crisis of the Late Republic

Gracchi, Marius, Sulla, Pompey, Caesar, and the destruction of negotiated restraint

The Republic's final century was not a straight march toward monarchy. Institutions continued to function, elections remained competitive, and many crises ended in compromise. Yet violence became repeatable, armies became instruments in domestic politics, and rivals increasingly treated defeat as ruin rather than temporary exclusion.

The Gracchi

Tiberius Gracchus, tribune in 133 BCE, proposed enforcing limits on occupation of public land and distributing recovered plots. When another tribune vetoed the measure, Tiberius had him removed by the plebeian assembly - an appeal to popular sovereignty that opponents considered an attack on tribunician independence. Tiberius was killed with many supporters by senators and their followers. His brother Gaius later advanced colonies, grain provisions, judicial reforms, and provincial measures before dying amid a senatorial emergency decree in 121 BCE.

The Gracchan episodes established destructive precedents on both sides: aggressive use of the assembly against colleagues, organized street politics, senatorial resort to lethal force, and the claim that political opponents threatened the state itself. The substantive issues - land, citizenship, grain, juries, and provincial abuse - remained unresolved.

Marius, Saturninus, and the Social War

Gaius Marius, a new man and celebrated general, held an unprecedented series of consulships during military emergencies. Recruitment increasingly included poorer citizens, while veterans expected commanders to help secure land. The violent politics of the tribune Saturninus showed how popular legislation, veteran settlement, and armed intimidation could combine. Soon afterward, Rome's Italian allies fought the Social War to obtain citizenship. Rome survived by extending citizenship, transforming the electorate and the political geography of Italy.

Sulla's march on Rome and dictatorship

In 88 BCE Lucius Cornelius Sulla marched his army on Rome after a popular law transferred his eastern command to Marius. This shattered the barrier between external command and domestic coercion. After civil war, Sulla became dictator "for making laws and settling the state." His proscriptions legalized killing and confiscation of named enemies. He enlarged the Senate, restored senatorial juries, restricted tribunes, and strengthened the regular cursus. His retirement showed personal confidence, but his constitutional settlement rested on terror and failed to remove the incentives for exceptional command.

Pompey, Crassus, and extraordinary power

Pompey received sweeping commands against Mediterranean piracy and Mithridates, bypassing ordinary provincial allocation. His successes reorganized the East, but the Senate delayed ratifying his settlements and land for veterans. The informal alliance of Pompey, Crassus, and Caesar - later called the First Triumvirate - coordinated elections and legislation outside normal senatorial consensus. It was not a legal board but a private coalition capable of overpowering resistance.

Caesar and civil war

Julius Caesar's conquest of Gaul gave him wealth, prestige, and a veteran army. Disputes over whether he could seek a second consulship without surrendering command became a struggle over prosecution, dignity, and survival. In January 49 BCE Caesar crossed the Rubicon, declaring civil war. He defeated Pompey and senatorial armies, accumulated repeated consulships and dictatorship, expanded citizenship and the Senate, reformed the calendar, settled veterans, and centralized decisions.

Caesar's title dictator perpetuo, dictator in perpetuity, and the honors surrounding him intensified fear of kingship. On the Ides of March 44 BCE, a group including Brutus and Cassius assassinated him in a senatorial meeting. They called the act liberation, but they had no military or political settlement capable of restoring the old Republic. Caesar's murder demonstrated that killing a ruler did not recreate the norms that had already collapsed.

"The die is cast." — Traditional rendering associated with Caesar's crossing of the Rubicon; the exact wording is disputed

Sources and further reading: Plutarch, *Lives*; Appian, *Civil Wars*; Sallust; Cicero's speeches and letters; Caesar, *Civil War*; Suetonius, *Julius Caesar*; Ronald Syme, *The Roman Revolution*; Erich Gruen, *The Last Generation of the Roman Republic*.

CHAPTER 10

From Caesar's Death to Augustus

Triumviral terror, Actium, and the creation of a durable monarchy without a royal title

Caesar's assassination opened a contest among his killers, his lieutenant Mark Antony, the Senate, armies seeking reward, and his eighteen-year-old adopted heir Gaius Octavius. Cicero tried to use Octavian against Antony and then restore senatorial leadership. Instead, Octavian, Antony, and Lepidus formed the legally empowered Second Triumvirate in 43 BCE.

The triumvirate and proscriptions

The triumvirs possessed extraordinary authority to "restore the state." They proscribed enemies, confiscated property, and financed war. Cicero was among those killed. At Philippi in 42 BCE, Antony and Octavian defeated Brutus and Cassius. The victors divided the Roman world and settled veterans on Italian land, creating both loyalty and suffering. Lepidus was later marginalized, leaving Antony dominant in the East and Octavian in the West.

Propaganda and Actium

The rivalry became a struggle over legitimacy. Octavian represented himself as defender of Italy, ancestral religion, and Roman family order; Antony's alliance and relationship with Cleopatra VII allowed opponents to depict him as subordinated to an eastern queen. In 31 BCE Octavian's forces under Agrippa defeated Antony and Cleopatra at Actium. Their deaths in 30 left Octavian in control of the entire Roman world.

Why Octavian did not become another Caesar

Open dictatorship had become politically toxic. Octavian instead demobilized some forces, rewarded veterans, restored temples, cultivated the Senate, and framed his supremacy as a return of lawful government. He retained decisive military provinces, immense wealth, networks of patronage, tribunician powers, and repeated consulships. The challenge was to make one-man rule appear compatible with republican forms and elite dignity.

The word "emperor"

Imperator originally hailed a victorious commander. Augustus used it as part of his name. The modern term "emperor" compresses a bundle of powers and honors rather than identifying one republican office that suddenly replaced all others.

Sources and further reading: Cicero, Philippics and letters; Appian, Civil Wars; Plutarch, Antony and Brutus; Cassius Dio; Velleius Paterculus; Ronald Syme; Werner Eck, The Age of Augustus.

CHAPTER 11

The Augustan Settlement

How republican offices became the legal language of imperial supremacy

In 27 BCE Octavian formally transferred control of the state to the Senate and people. The Senate granted him the honorific Augustus and assigned him command over a group of provinces containing most of the legions. This “first settlement” did not make him a private citizen. It gave constitutional form to military predominance. In 23 BCE a second adjustment allowed him to leave the consulship while retaining superior proconsular authority and tribunician power.

The principal components of Augustan power

- Imperium proconsulare: command over imperial provinces and their armies, eventually understood as superior when his authority intersected with other governors.
- Tribunicia potestas: the powers and sacrosanct status of a tribune without holding the plebeian office, enabling initiative, veto, protection, and annual dating of his reign.
- Auctoritas: personal prestige derived from victory, wealth, ancestry by adoption, religious leadership, and the capacity to reward.
- Control of patronage: influence over offices, provincial appointments, military careers, citizenship, grants, contracts, and access to the ruler.
- Religious authority: membership in priestly colleges and, from 12 BCE, the office of pontifex maximus.
- Financial and military resources: command of permanent legions, the Praetorian Guard, veteran colonies, imperial estates, and evolving treasuries.

Augustus’ own Res Gestae claimed that after transferring the state he surpassed others in auctoritas while possessing no more official power than colleagues in each magistracy. The formulation was artful. No colleague combined his commands, tenure, prestige, and resources. Republican vocabulary concealed a new asymmetry: magistrates still held office, but one man could remain continuously above the competitive cycle.

Reforming the Senate

Civil war and Caesar’s appointments had enlarged and diversified the Senate. Augustus conducted reviews, expelled members judged unqualified, raised the property expectation, encouraged attendance, regulated speaking and meeting days, and promoted selected men. He presented these measures as restoring dignity. They also made membership dependent on imperial supervision. The princeps could recommend candidates, accelerate careers, and shape the body without abolishing it.

Elections under Augustus

Popular elections continued, and competition did not vanish immediately. Yet imperial commendation and nomination increasingly determined which candidates could succeed. Augustus sometimes tried to preserve a semblance of choice among approved men. Under Tiberius, the effective election of major magistrates was transferred from the assemblies to the Senate, though public ceremonies and residual procedures remained. The people’s electoral sovereignty became symbolic as imperial and senatorial selection took over.

The meaning of princeps

Augustus preferred princeps, “first citizen” or “leading man,” rather than king. Modern historians call the early imperial system the Principate because monarchy operated through republican forms. This was not mere deception. Forms shaped expectations: emperors sought senatorial decrees, held or imitated magistracies, presented accounts, accepted honors, and were judged according to whether they respected elite liberty. But the ultimate foundation was victory and control of the armed forces.

“I transferred the republic from my power to the control of the Senate and Roman people.” — Augustus, Res Gestae 34, in the ruler’s official account

Sources and further reading: Augustus, Res Gestae; Cassius Dio, Books 53-56; Suetonius, Augustus; Tacitus, Annals 1; Werner Eck; Ronald Syme; Fergus Millar, The Emperor in the Roman World; Alison Cooley, Res Gestae Divi Augusti.

CHAPTER 12

The Senate Under the Emperors

Prestige, administration, law, servility, resistance, and survival from Augustus to late antiquity

The imperial Senate remained a central public institution, but its role depended on the emperor's personality, the army, court politics, and the wider administrative system. It could not routinely choose grand strategy against the ruler's wishes. It could, however, confer honors, manage senatorial provinces, conduct trials, enact decrees, distribute offices, preserve elite status, and serve as an arena in which the emperor's relationship with the aristocracy became visible.

The Senate as legislature and court

As popular assemblies ceased to pass significant laws, *senatus consulta* acquired legislative force. Often an emperor or magistrate introduced the policy, and jurists treated the resulting decree as law. The Senate also heard extortion cases, adultery and status cases, treason charges, and accusations involving its own members. Judicial dignity could become political danger: under Tiberius and later rulers, informers used *maiestas* prosecutions to target wealthy or outspoken senators.

Provincial government and careers

Augustus divided provinces conventionally into imperial and senatorial spheres. The Senate assigned proconsuls to peaceful provinces such as Asia and Africa, while the emperor controlled most frontier armies through legates. Senators still commanded legions and governed imperial provinces, making the order indispensable. From Gallienus in the third century, equestrian officers increasingly displaced senators from military commands, accelerating a separation between civil prestige and battlefield authority.

Election, recommendation, and imperial control

After Tiberius transferred electoral decisions to the Senate, candidacies were increasingly managed through imperial recommendation. The Senate voted and ranked candidates, but the emperor could designate, commend, or exclude. Consulships became shorter and more numerous, allowing more senators to receive the supreme honor while reducing its executive substance. The consulship remained the gateway to prestigious governorships and a public marker of rank.

Good emperors and bad emperors

Senatorial authors praised emperors who listened, shared honors, avoided arbitrary executions, respected property, and allowed frank speech. They condemned rulers who humiliated senators, elevated performers or freedmen above them, confiscated estates, staged treason trials, or demanded divine honors. These standards explain the reputations of Caligula, Nero, Domitian, Commodus, and Elagabalus. Some accusations are credible; others reflect elite disgust at cultural and status violations as much as administrative failure.

Opposition and the "Stoic" ideal

A minority of senators resisted through speeches, refusal, conspiracy, philosophical withdrawal, or cultivated martyrdom. Figures such as Thrasea Paetus and Helvidius Priscus were celebrated for principled independence under Nero and the Flavians. Yet opposition was rarely a coherent republican program. Most senators sought honorable participation under monarchy, not restoration of the assemblies and annual military command.

The Dominate and two Senates

The reforms of Diocletian and Constantine made imperial monarchy more explicit, enlarged bureaucracy, multiplied provinces, and separated civil from military careers. Constantine founded a Senate at Constantinople, eventually equal in rank to Rome's. Membership expanded dramatically and became a broad hereditary status with graded titles. The old Roman Senate retained wealth and urban influence, but strategic power followed the mobile court, armies, and imperial capitals.

The western Senate after 476

The deposition of Romulus Augustulus did not dissolve the Senate. Roman senators negotiated with Odoacer and the Ostrogothic kings, held offices, maintained estates, sponsored buildings, and communicated with Constantinople. The body disappears from evidence in the early seventh century after wars, plague, demographic contraction, and the transformation of Italy. Its lifespan - from archaic legend into the medieval world - is one of the longest institutional continuities in political history.

Was the imperial Senate powerless?

It lacked independent control over the army and could not reliably oppose a secure emperor. But "power" also included appointments, jurisdiction, legislation, wealth, urban administration, provincial government, social recognition, and the ability to legitimize or stigmatize a ruler. In those fields the Senate remained consequential.

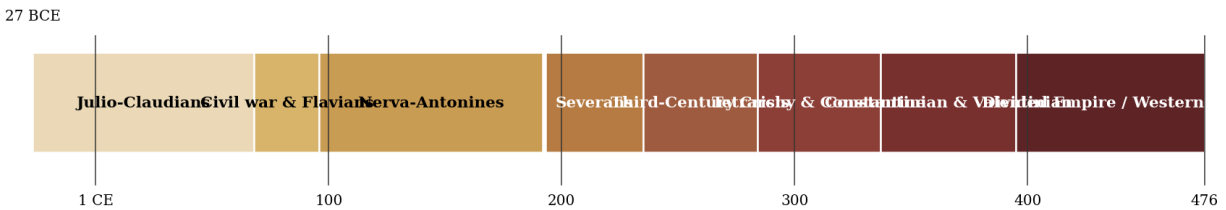
Sources and further reading: Tacitus, *Annals and Histories*; Pliny, *Panegyric and Letters*; Cassius Dio; imperial law codes; Richard Talbert, *The Senate of Imperial Rome*; Fergus Millar, *The Emperor in the Roman World*; A. H. M. Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*; John Matthews, *Western Aristocracies and Imperial Court*.

CHAPTER 13

The Emperors: How to Read the Succession

Dynasty, army, Senate, court, and the repeated problem of legitimate transfer

From the Principate to the end of the Western imperial office



The Eastern Roman Empire continued after 476; "Byzantine" is a later scholarly label, not the empire's own name.

A simplified map of the major political eras from Augustus to the end of the Western imperial office.

Rome never established a single, uncontested law of succession. Emperors tried adoption, heredity, designation as Caesar, marriage alliances, co-rule, and acclamation by the army. The Senate might confirm a ruler, declare a public enemy, or ratify honors, but military control and recognition by other imperial centers usually mattered more. Stable dynasties made monarchy look hereditary; civil wars revealed that it was also elective in the brutal sense that armies, courts, and political coalitions chose among contenders.

The profiles below use the same four questions: How did the ruler reach power? What did the government build, reform, conquer, or preserve? What controversies, persecutions, fiscal pressures, court struggles, or military failures defined the reign? And how did the ruler treat the Senate and reshape the imperial office?

CHAPTER 14

The Julio-Claudians: The Household Becomes a Dynasty

Augustus, succession experiments, court politics, and the first tests of senatorial monarchy

Augustus created a system that denied being hereditary monarchy while depending heavily on his family. Deaths, divorces, adoptions, and dynastic marriages narrowed the succession to Tiberius. Thereafter the imperial household, Praetorian Guard, Senate, army, and urban crowd repeatedly negotiated who counted as Caesar. The dynasty's fall showed both the strength of the office and the absence of an agreed succession rule.

The Julio-Claudian dilemma

The emperor needed an heir strong enough to inherit armies and patronage but not so independent that he became a rival. Adoption and shared tribunician or military power served as designation, yet blood relationship remained politically compelling.

Augustus

27 BCE-14 CE | Julio-Claudian founder

Accession and setting: Octavian emerged from the civil wars as Caesar's adopted son and sole victor after Actium. The settlements of 27 and 23 BCE gave republican form to his command of the principal armies, tribunician powers, and unmatched *auctoritas*.

Government and contributions: He stabilized taxation and provincial administration, professionalized the standing army, established the Praetorian Guard and military treasury, rebuilt Rome, encouraged marriage and moral legislation, sponsored literature, and oversaw expansion in Spain, the Alps, the Balkans, and Egypt.

Controversies and conflict: His regime arose from proscriptions, confiscations, civil war, and the destruction of rivals. Moral laws intruded into elite families; succession plans repeatedly failed; the Varian disaster in 9 CE destroyed three legions; and official "restoration" language masked permanent one-man predominance.

Senate and historical legacy: Augustus cultivated senatorial dignity while revising membership and managing elections. He became the model princeps: later emperors were judged by whether they combined his control with his restraint. His greatest contribution was not a single reform but a monarchy that could survive its founder.

Tiberius

14-37 | Julio-Claudian

Accession and setting: Augustus' stepson was an experienced general and administrator, adopted only after earlier heirs died. His accession was legally elaborate: Senate and army recognized a position already made nearly unavoidable by shared powers and family designation.

Government and contributions: Tiberius kept finances strong, governed provinces cautiously, limited expensive expansion after Germanicus' campaigns, and often respected administrative competence. He refused many excessive honors and initially emphasized cooperation with the Senate.

Controversies and conflict: Ancient sources portray a darkening reign marked by *maiestas* trials, informers, suspicion, and the rise and fall of the Praetorian prefect Sejanus. His withdrawal to Capri allowed court intrigue and fear to dominate Rome; scandalous sexual stories are difficult to verify.

Senate and historical legacy: Tacitus made Tiberius the classic study of concealed monarchy and senatorial servility. He transferred effective elections from popular assemblies to the Senate, increasing its formal role while exposing its dependence. His reputation remains divided between capable fiscal ruler and isolated autocrat.

Gaius Caligula

37-41 | Julio-Claudian

Accession and setting: Germanicus' surviving son was greeted enthusiastically after Tiberius. His family popularity, support of the Praetorians, and rapid senatorial recognition outweighed his limited governing experience.

Government and contributions: He distributed gifts, restored some exiles, began major building works and aqueducts, promoted imperial cult policy in the provinces, and planned ambitious campaigns. Some administrative measures suggest an active court rather than unbroken chaos.

Controversies and conflict: Hostile sources accuse him of cruelty, sexual transgression, confiscation, theatrical humiliation of senators, divine pretensions, and erratic military displays. The famous plan to place his statue in the Jerusalem Temple risked major revolt. Distinguishing fact from elite invective is unusually difficult.

Senate and historical legacy: Caligula's assassination by Praetorian officers revealed the emperor's personal vulnerability. Senators briefly discussed restoring the Republic, but the Guard acclaimed Claudius. The episode showed that imperial office, army, and dynasty were already stronger than republican nostalgia.

Claudius

41-54 | Julio-Claudian

Accession and setting: Caligula's uncle was found and acclaimed by the Praetorian Guard after the assassination. The Senate accepted him when it became clear that armed support and Julio-Claudian legitimacy made alternatives unrealistic.

Government and contributions: Claudius conquered Britain, annexed or reorganized client kingdoms, expanded the port at Ostia, built aqueducts, improved judicial and administrative routines, and admitted provincial elites. His surviving Lyon speech argues that Rome had always renewed itself by incorporating outsiders.

Controversies and conflict: Ancient accounts ridicule his disabilities and depict domination by freedmen and wives, especially Messalina and Agrippina. Court trials, executions, confiscations, and uncertain decision-making damaged trust. His marriage to his niece Agrippina and adoption of Nero destabilized Britannicus' succession.

Senate and historical legacy: Claudius used senatorial institutions but often bypassed aristocrats through imperial freedmen and household departments. His reign accelerated professional central administration and provincial inclusion, even as elite writers treated those same developments as humiliations.

Nero

54-68 | Julio-Claudian

Accession and setting: Adopted by Claudius and promoted by Agrippina, Nero became emperor at sixteen. Seneca, Burrus, and the Senate guided an initially moderate government while Britannicus and later Agrippina were removed as dynastic threats.

Government and contributions: Early policies reduced some taxes and encouraged judicial restraint. Nero pursued diplomacy with Parthia over Armenia, rebuilt Rome after the great fire with wider streets and fire precautions, and sponsored Greek culture, athletics, music, and monumental architecture.

Controversies and conflict: He ordered or consented to deaths within his family, punished Christians after the fire, suppressed the Pisonian conspiracy, and faced accusations of extravagance and confiscation. His public performance offended senatorial ideas of dignity. Revolts in Gaul and Spain exposed declining military loyalty.

Senate and historical legacy: The Senate declared Nero a public enemy after Galba's revolt, and he died by suicide. Later eastern traditions sometimes expected his return, while senators celebrated liberation. His fall ended the dynasty and proved that an emperor could be made outside Rome by provincial armies.

Sources and further reading: Tacitus, *Annals*; Suetonius, *Lives of the Caesars*; Cassius Dio; Velleius Paterculus; inscriptions and coinage; Barbara Levick, *Tiberius the Politician*; Anthony Barrett, *Caligula and Claudius*; Miriam Griffin, *Nero*.

CHAPTER 15

Civil War and the Flavians

The Year of Four Emperors and the reconstruction of imperial authority

Nero's death exposed the military foundations of the Principate. In 68-69, governors and legions in Spain, Germany, the Danube, the East, and Africa became decisive political actors. Vespasian's victory restored stability, but the Flavian dynasty could no longer pretend that succession depended mainly on the old Roman aristocracy.

Historical setting

Tacitus summarized the lesson of 69: the secret of empire was revealed - an emperor could be made elsewhere than at Rome. The Senate ratified outcomes created by armies, though its support, decrees, and ceremonies still converted victory into public legitimacy.

Galba

68-69 | Civil war of 68-69

Accession and setting: Governor of Hispania Tarraconensis, Galba joined rebellion against Nero and was recognized after Nero's collapse. He presented himself as the Senate's choice and a restorer of discipline.

Government and contributions: He attempted fiscal retrenchment, punished some Neronian agents, and refused to buy military loyalty with indiscriminate gifts. He adopted Piso Licinianus to create an orderly, aristocratic succession.

Controversies and conflict: His austerity alienated troops expecting a donative, while harsh actions and poor advisers undermined goodwill. By choosing Piso he offended Otho, whose supporters secured the Praetorian Guard.

Senate and historical legacy: Galba was killed in the Forum after about seven months. His reign showed that senatorial rank and moral seriousness could not compensate for failure to manage soldiers, money, and succession.

Otho

69 | Civil war of 68-69

Accession and setting: A former associate of Nero and governor of Lusitania, Otho organized Galba's overthrow after being passed over as heir. The Praetorians acclaimed him and the Senate recognized the accomplished coup.

Government and contributions: He reconciled some Neronian supporters, tried to maintain urban order, and moved quickly against Vitellius' Rhine armies. His administration was brief but not the caricature of mere luxury found in hostile moralizing.

Controversies and conflict: His accession rested on assassination and military bribery. Defeat at the first battle of Bedriacum left him with options to continue the war, but at grave cost.

Senate and historical legacy: Otho committed suicide to prevent further Roman deaths, earning unexpected praise from ancient authors. His choice became a model of how a compromised ruler could die with civic restraint.

Vitellius

69 | Civil war of 68-69

Accession and setting: Rhine legions proclaimed Vitellius while Galba still ruled. His generals defeated Otho and brought him to Rome, where the Senate conferred the imperial titles.

Government and contributions: He rewarded supporters, revised some court appointments, and tried to ground his rule in the victorious German armies. Several administrative acts survived his fall.

Controversies and conflict: Ancient narratives emphasize gluttony, indiscipline, executions, and inability to control troops. The eastern and Danubian legions backed Vespasian, while Vitellian forces fought a second civil war in Italy. Rome itself became a battlefield and the Capitoline temple burned.

Senate and historical legacy: Vitellius was killed after Vespasian's forces entered the city. His treatment in Flavian sources illustrates how victors shaped the moral memory of defeated emperors.

Vespasian

69-79 | Flavian

Accession and setting: A successful commander from an Italian municipal family, Vespasian was proclaimed by eastern armies during the Jewish War. Danubian support and victory in Italy secured his recognition.

Government and contributions: He restored fiscal stability, rebuilt after civil war and fire, began the Colosseum, regularized imperial powers, expanded elite recruitment from Italy and provinces, and completed major campaigns in Judaea and Britain through his generals.

Controversies and conflict: New taxes and aggressive revenue collection generated jokes and resentment. The destruction of Jerusalem in 70 was catastrophic for Jewish society. He executed or marginalized some opponents but generally avoided the pervasive terror associated with later reigns.

Senate and historical legacy: The *lex de imperio Vespasiani* publicly enumerated broad powers in republican language. Vespasian attended the Senate while ensuring dynastic succession for Titus and Domitian. His practical, unpretentious image became a counterpoint to Nero and civil war.

Titus

79-81 | Flavian

Accession and setting: Vespasian's elder son had commanded the siege of Jerusalem and served as designated heir, sharing tribunician and administrative powers. His orderly accession was the first natural father-to-son transfer of the Principate.

Government and contributions: He completed and dedicated the Colosseum, provided relief after the eruption of Vesuvius and a major fire in Rome, and cultivated clemency. His brief reign was remembered as unusually generous.

Controversies and conflict: His earlier role as Praetorian prefect and the destruction of Jerusalem gave him a severe reputation before accession. The relationship with the Jewish queen Berenice was politically controversial at Rome. Some favorable memories may reflect contrast with Domitian.

Senate and historical legacy: Titus worked smoothly with the Senate and died of illness after only two years. Ancient writers cast him as a ruler transformed by office, though the short reign limits firm judgment.

Domitian

81-96 | Flavian

Accession and setting: Titus' younger brother succeeded without serious opposition. He possessed long experience at court but had been kept from equivalent command and prominence during the earlier Flavian reigns.

Government and contributions: He strengthened frontier defenses, raised soldiers' pay, conducted campaigns on the Rhine and Danube, supported provincial administration, regulated coinage, rebuilt monumental Rome, and took an active interest in justice. Modern scholarship often credits his administrative competence.

Controversies and conflict: His autocratic style, censorship, court ceremony, trials, executions, and conflicts with philosophers and senators created deep hostility. The Dacian settlement was mocked as humiliating despite strategic logic. Sources accuse him of demanding the title "lord and god," though usage is debated.

Senate and historical legacy: A palace conspiracy killed Domitian, and the Senate imposed condemnation of memory. Military affection for him complicated the succession. His reputation shows the distance between effective administration and senatorial standards of acceptable rule.

Sources and further reading: Tacitus, *Histories*; Suetonius; Josephus, *Jewish War*; Cassius Dio; inscriptions including the *lex de imperio Vespasiani*; Gwyn Morgan, 69 A.D.; Brian Jones, *The Emperor Domitian*.

CHAPTER 16

The Adoptive and Antonine Emperors

Elite cooperation, expansion, consolidation, and the pressures beneath the “golden age”

From Nerva to Marcus Aurelius, succession was often arranged through adoption of an adult heir, though heredity and circumstance still mattered. Later memory idealized the period as rule by capable emperors chosen for merit. In reality, each adoption solved a specific dynastic problem, and the era ended when Marcus Aurelius had a surviving son.

Historical setting

The Empire reached its greatest territorial extent under Trajan, then shifted toward consolidation under Hadrian and Antoninus Pius. Prosperity depended on taxation, coerced labor, slavery, local elite government, and military security; it was never an age without conflict.

Nerva

96-98 | Nerva-Antonine

Accession and setting: After Domitian’s assassination, the Senate chose the elderly consular Nerva. He offered aristocratic legitimacy and distance from the slain dynasty but lacked a strong military base.

Government and contributions: He recalled exiles, limited treason prosecutions, distributed land to some poor citizens, and adopted the highly respected general Trajan after a Praetorian mutiny exposed his weakness.

Controversies and conflict: Financial strain and the Guard’s coercion humiliated his government. He could not punish Domitian’s assassins or fully control soldiers still loyal to the Flavian ruler.

Senate and historical legacy: Nerva’s adoption of Trajan turned weakness into a durable settlement. The Senate honored him as a restorer of liberty, and later tradition treated him as the first of the “five good emperors.”

Trajan

98-117 | Nerva-Antonine

Accession and setting: An experienced commander from Hispania, Trajan was adopted by Nerva and succeeded while on the Rhine. Military prestige and senatorial approval combined without civil war.

Government and contributions: He conquered Dacia, annexed its resources, campaigned deep into the Parthian world, expanded roads, harbors and welfare schemes, developed Rome’s Forum and markets, and promoted a cooperative image. His correspondence with Pliny illuminates provincial administration.

Controversies and conflict: The Parthian conquests proved difficult to hold; Jewish revolts devastated eastern regions; and warfare imposed major costs. His reputation for consultation coexisted with imperial command and harsh conquest, including the final defeat of Dacia.

Senate and historical legacy: The Senate awarded him *optimus princeps*, “best ruler.” Trajan became a benchmark for military and civic excellence, though Hadrian abandoned much of his eastern expansion as unsustainable.

Hadrian

117-138 | Nerva-Antonine

Accession and setting: Hadrian, Trajan’s relative and former ward, was proclaimed after a disputed deathbed adoption. The eastern army supported him, and the Senate recognized the succession.

Government and contributions: He consolidated frontiers, built fortifications including Hadrian's Wall, traveled extensively, inspected armies, codified the praetorian edict, patronized Greek culture, and rebuilt the Pantheon. He emphasized defensible borders over unlimited conquest.

Controversies and conflict: Four leading senators were executed early in the reign while Hadrian was absent, permanently damaging relations. The Bar Kokhba revolt followed Roman policies in Judaea and ended with enormous destruction and displacement. His final years included illness, executions, and a troubled succession.

Senate and historical legacy: Hadrian used the Senate but relied heavily on expert administration and personal inspection. His reign marked the maturing of a cosmopolitan, bureaucratic empire centered on the mobile emperor.

Antoninus Pius

138-161 | Nerva-Antonine

Accession and setting: Hadrian adopted Antoninus on condition that he adopt Marcus Aurelius and Lucius Verus. A wealthy, respected senator, Antoninus secured Hadrian's deification despite senatorial resentment.

Government and contributions: His long reign emphasized legal administration, fiscal prudence, repair, provincial stability, and measured frontier activity. The Antonine Wall in Britain briefly advanced beyond Hadrian's line. Juristic development and charitable foundations flourished.

Controversies and conflict: Ancient sources preserve fewer dramatic events, which may conceal unrest and local conflict. Critics can view his limited travel and strategic caution as postponing frontier problems, though this judgment relies heavily on hindsight.

Senate and historical legacy: Antoninus' deference earned the surname Pius and excellent senatorial memory. His reign became the ideal of peaceful paternal monarchy, supported by competent governors and heirs already integrated into government.

Marcus Aurelius

161-180 | Nerva-Antonine

Accession and setting: Antoninus' adopted son had been prepared for rule for decades. He shared power with Lucius Verus, presenting collegial monarchy rather than excluding his adoptive brother.

Government and contributions: He managed the Parthian War through Verus and generals, confronted Germanic invasions along the Danube, sold palace valuables during fiscal pressure, developed law and administration, and left the philosophical *Meditations*. His government survived plague and sustained war.

Controversies and conflict: The Antonine plague caused severe mortality and disruption. Christians suffered local persecutions, including at Lyon, although no empire-wide decree from Marcus is proven. The revolt of Avidius Cassius exposed succession anxiety. Continuous warfare challenged the philosopher-king image.

Senate and historical legacy: Marcus respected senatorial forms and brought senators into command, but military emergency dominated his reign. His decision to elevate his biological son Commodus ended the pattern of adoptive succession and has long shaped criticism of his judgment.

Lucius Verus

161-169 | Nerva-Antonine co-emperor

Accession and setting: Adopted with Marcus Aurelius, Verus received equal imperial titles in 161, the first sustained formal co-emperorship at this level. Marcus remained the senior political figure.

Government and contributions: Verus traveled east during the Parthian War while generals captured major cities and restored Roman influence in Armenia and Mesopotamia. Co-rule provided dynastic unity and distributed ceremonial burden.

Controversies and conflict: Sources accuse him of luxury and detachment in Antioch, perhaps reflecting contrast with Marcus' austere image. Returning troops may have helped spread the Antonine plague, though the pathogen's origin and routes remain debated.

Senate and historical legacy: Verus died suddenly in 169, probably from illness. His deification and generally harmonious partnership showed that shared imperial rank could work when hierarchy and trust were clear.

Commodus

177/180-192 | Antonine

Accession and setting: Marcus made Commodus co-emperor in 177; he became sole ruler in 180. He was the first emperor born during his father's reign and possessed unquestioned dynastic legitimacy.

Government and contributions: He ended the exhausting Danubian war, maintained portions of the administration, and cultivated support among soldiers and the urban populace through games and largesse.

Controversies and conflict: Palace favorites, executions, confiscations, conspiracies, and unstable policy damaged government. Commodus presented himself as a new Hercules, renamed months and institutions, and fought publicly as a gladiator, acts that aristocrats viewed as monstrous violations of status. A grain crisis and court violence deepened instability.

Senate and historical legacy: His chamberlain, mistress, and Praetorian prefect arranged his murder. The Senate condemned his memory, though Septimius Severus later rehabilitated him for dynastic purposes. His death reopened civil war and marked the end of the Antonine settlement.

Sources and further reading: Pliny, *Panegyric and Letters*; Cassius Dio; *Historia Augusta* (cautiously); inscriptions; Fronto; Galen; Anthony Birley, *Marcus Aurelius and Hadrian*; Julian Bennett, *Trajan*; Fergus Millar.

CHAPTER 17

The Severans and the Third-Century Crisis

Military monarchy, universal citizenship, rapid succession, invasion, plague, and recovery

After Commodus, emperors increasingly depended on direct military support, donatives, and court networks. The Severans rebuilt dynasty after civil war, but assassination and succession breakdown opened decades in which rulers rose and fell with frontier armies. The term “Third-Century Crisis” describes intertwined wars, usurpations, epidemics, fiscal change, and political fragmentation - not uninterrupted collapse.

Historical setting

Between 235 and 284, many emperors ruled only months or a few years. Yet armies continued campaigning, cities and provinces adapted, and rulers such as Gallienus, Aurelian, and Probus restored significant capacity. The crisis transformed the imperial office before Diocletian reorganized it.

Pertinax

193 | Post-Antonine transition

Accession and setting: A respected senator and former commander, Pertinax was elevated after Commodus’ murder and recognized by the Senate.

Government and contributions: He attempted to restore discipline, reduce extravagance, repair finances, and reverse some confiscations.

Controversies and conflict: The Praetorians resented strict discipline and inadequate rewards. After eighty-six days they killed him inside the palace.

Senate and historical legacy: The Senate honored Pertinax after Septimius Severus’ victory. His fall demonstrated that senatorial virtue without control of the Guard could not secure the throne.

Didius Julianus

193 | Post-Antonine transition

Accession and setting: After murdering Pertinax, the Praetorians effectively auctioned their support. The wealthy consular Julianus offered the largest donative and received reluctant senatorial recognition.

Government and contributions: He tried to issue orders and negotiate with provincial commanders, but possessed little legitimacy beyond the Guard.

Controversies and conflict: Public hostility was immediate. Septimius Severus, Pescennius Niger, and Clodius Albinus were backed by provincial armies. When Severus approached Rome, the Senate condemned Julianus.

Senate and historical legacy: Executed after roughly two months, Julianus became the clearest symbol of imperial office treated as military property.

Septimius Severus

193-211 | Severan

Accession and setting: Commander of the Danubian legions, Severus marched on Rome, disbanded the old Praetorian Guard, defeated Niger in the East and Albinus in the West, and founded a new dynasty.

Government and contributions: He increased soldiers' pay, permitted legal military families, strengthened frontiers, campaigned in Parthia and Britain, enlarged the imperial administration, and sponsored major building. Jurists such as Papinian served his government.

Controversies and conflict: Civil wars, executions, confiscations, and favor toward the army burdened elite relations and finances. He claimed adoption into the Antonine line and rehabilitated Commodus to manufacture legitimacy.

Senate and historical legacy: Severus reduced the political independence of the Senate while still employing senators. His reported deathbed advice to his sons - enrich the soldiers and scorn the rest - may be literary, but accurately captures his military monarchy.

Caracalla

198/211-217 | Severan

Accession and setting: Severus made Caracalla co-emperor; after their father's death he ruled with his brother Geta before arranging Geta's murder and becoming sole emperor.

Government and contributions: The Constitutio Antoniniana of 212 granted Roman citizenship to nearly all free inhabitants of the Empire, a profound legal integration. He built the great baths at Rome, increased army pay, and campaigned on the Rhine and in the East.

Controversies and conflict: Geta was killed in their mother's presence, followed by purges of alleged supporters. Caracalla's fiscal needs encouraged currency debasement and taxation. The massacre at Alexandria and an aggressive Parthian war darkened the reign.

Senate and historical legacy: His citizenship edict expanded Roman law and identity while his personal rule exemplified dynastic violence. He was assassinated during campaign by officers linked to Macrinus.

Geta

209-211 | Severan co-emperor

Accession and setting: The younger son of Septimius Severus was elevated to Augustus and inherited jointly with Caracalla.

Government and contributions: His formal role was to preserve dynastic partnership, and coins and ceremonies advertised concord.

Controversies and conflict: The brothers divided the palace, feared assassination, and allegedly considered partition of the Empire. Caracalla had Geta killed and ordered a purge; Geta's name and images were erased in a famous condemnation of memory.

Senate and historical legacy: Geta's brief co-rule reveals the danger of equal dynastic rank without an accepted senior partner. The surviving images altered after his death are exceptional evidence for memory politics.

Macrinus

217-218 | Interlude

Accession and setting: Praetorian prefect Macrinus helped organize Caracalla's assassination and became the first emperor who had not served as a senator. The eastern army and Senate accepted him after the fact.

Government and contributions: He sought peace with Parthia, attempted fiscal restraint, and reduced some new soldiers' pay while preserving rates for existing troops.

Controversies and conflict: The settlement with Parthia was portrayed as humiliating, and military economies undermined his base. Julia Maesa promoted her grandson Elagabalus as Caracalla's son, triggering revolt.

Senate and historical legacy: Macrinus was defeated and executed. His equestrian origin foreshadowed the declining monopoly of senators over imperial and military command.

Elagabalus

218-222 | Severan restoration

Accession and setting: The teenage priest Varius Avitus was proclaimed in Syria as Caracalla's alleged son and took the imperial name Marcus Aurelius Antoninus.

Government and contributions: He brought the Emesene sun god Elagabal to Rome, promoted a universal solar cult, distributed favors, and adopted his cousin Severus Alexander under pressure.

Controversies and conflict: Ancient accounts describe sexual scandal, unconventional dress, marriages, court favorites, and ritual innovations. Some details are hostile invention, but his attempt to place his god above Jupiter and disregard Roman elite norms provoked intense opposition.

Senate and historical legacy: The Praetorians killed Elagabalus and his mother. The Senate condemned his memory. His reign is a warning against reading elite disgust as simple fact, while still recognizing genuine religious and political conflict.

Severus Alexander

222-235 | Severan

Accession and setting: Elagabalus' cousin succeeded at thirteen under the strong influence of Julia Mamaea and a council of senators and jurists.

Government and contributions: His government cultivated moderation, restored senatorial participation, sponsored building, and responded to the new Sasanian Persian power and Germanic threats.

Controversies and conflict: The Persian campaign produced mixed results. On the Rhine, attempts to negotiate or pay enemies angered troops who wanted aggressive leadership. Dependence on his mother was ridiculed by hostile soldiers.

Senate and historical legacy: Alexander and Mamaea were murdered in a mutiny that elevated Maximinus. His death conventionally begins the acute Third-Century Crisis.

Maximinus Thrax

235-238 | Barracks emperor

Accession and setting: A commander of humble provincial background, Maximinus was acclaimed by Rhine troops after Alexander's murder and never visited Rome as emperor.

Government and contributions: He campaigned energetically across the Rhine and Danube, maintaining frontier pressure at a moment of serious threat.

Controversies and conflict: Heavy requisitions, exclusion of senators, and military taxation generated hostility. Revolt began in Africa and the Senate declared him an enemy, supporting several rival emperors.

Senate and historical legacy: His own troops killed him during the failed siege of Aquileia. His reign symbolizes the transfer of imperial selection from senatorial aristocracy to frontier armies.

Gordian I and Gordian II

238 | African revolt

Accession and setting: Landowners and officials in Africa proclaimed the elderly proconsul Gordian I and his son Gordian II against Maximinus. The Senate recognized them and organized resistance.

Government and contributions: Their revolt provided a senatorial rallying point and spread opposition to Maximinus.

Controversies and conflict: Numidian forces loyal to Maximinus defeated and killed Gordian II near Carthage; Gordian I committed suicide. Their joint reign lasted only weeks.

Senate and historical legacy: The Senate deified them after victory and later elevated Gordian III. Their failure shows both the reach and military weakness of aristocratic revolt.

Pupienus and Balbinus

238 | Senatorial emperors

Accession and setting: After the Gordians fell, the Senate selected two senior statesmen: Pupienus to direct war and Balbinus to manage Rome. Popular pressure forced them to accept the young Gordian III as Caesar.

Government and contributions: Pupienus' mobilization coincided with Maximinus' assassination, and the regime briefly represented collective senatorial government.

Controversies and conflict: The co-emperors distrusted each other, lacked popular affection, and angered the Praetorians. The Guard broke into the palace and killed both.

Senate and historical legacy: Their deaths ended the Senate's most explicit attempt to choose and govern through emperors of its own selection.

Gordian III

238-244 | Gordian

Accession and setting: The grandson or nephew of Gordian I became Augustus at about thirteen after Pupienus and Balbinus were murdered.

Government and contributions: His government restored symbolic unity, relied on the capable prefect Timesitheus, and launched a major campaign against Sasanian Persia that initially recovered territory.

Controversies and conflict: After Timesitheus died, Philip the Arab became prefect. Gordian died during the Persian campaign; Roman and Persian accounts differ on whether he fell in battle or was murdered by his own men.

Senate and historical legacy: His youth made court and army officials decisive. His popularity at Rome outlived a reign whose true decision-makers are difficult to reconstruct.

Philip the Arab

244-249 | Military emperor

Accession and setting: Praetorian prefect Philip succeeded Gordian during the Persian campaign, made peace with Shapur I, and secured senatorial recognition.

Government and contributions: He celebrated Rome's one-thousandth anniversary in 248, appointed relatives to key commands, and attempted to stabilize frontiers and finances.

Controversies and conflict: The Persian peace required payment; invasions and provincial rebellions multiplied. Later Christian writers sometimes claimed Philip was Christian, but evidence is insufficient.

Senate and historical legacy: Decius' Danubian army defeated and killed him. His reign shows the constant need to convert a frontier acclamation into Roman and senatorial legitimacy.

Decius

249-251 | Military emperor

Accession and setting: Sent to suppress rebellion on the Danube, Decius was proclaimed by his troops and defeated Philip.

Government and contributions: He fought Gothic invaders, emphasized traditional Roman religion, and required inhabitants to certify sacrifice for the safety of the Empire.

Controversies and conflict: The sacrifice edict produced the first empire-wide pressure on Christians, leading to imprisonment, death, compliance, and later church disputes over the "lapsed." In 251 Decius and his son Herennius Etruscus died fighting Goths at Abritus.

Senate and historical legacy: Decius was the first Roman emperor killed in battle against a foreign enemy. His policy joined religious restoration to imperial loyalty rather than targeting theology alone.

Trebonianus Gallus and Volusian

251-253 | Military emperors

Accession and setting: Troops elevated Gallus after Decius' death; he associated Decius' younger son Hostilian and then his own son Volusian. Hostilian soon died, probably in an epidemic.

Government and contributions: Gallus made a difficult settlement with the Goths and faced the continuing plague and Persian pressure.

Controversies and conflict: The treaty was criticized as disgraceful. Aemilian's victory over Goths won him army support, and Gallus' troops killed Gallus and Volusian before battle.

Senate and historical legacy: The reign illustrates how rapidly frontier success could overturn recognition by Rome and the Senate.

Aemilian

253 | Military emperor

Accession and setting: Governor of Moesia, Aemilian was proclaimed after defeating Gothic raiders and marched toward Italy.

Government and contributions: His only clear contribution was the restoration of military confidence on the Danube.

Controversies and conflict: He defeated Gallus' regime but faced Valerian, commander of larger Rhine forces. Aemilian's own men killed him after only a few months.

Senate and historical legacy: His reign epitomizes the compressed political cycle of acclamation, march, senatorial recognition, and assassination.

Valerian

253-260 | Valerianic

Accession and setting: A senior senator and commander, Valerian was proclaimed against Aemilian and shared rule with his son Gallienus, dividing responsibility between eastern and western fronts.

Government and contributions: He responded to Persian invasion, attempted to restore authority in the East, and established a practical model of geographically divided imperial labor.

Controversies and conflict: Valerian issued harsh anti-Christian measures targeting clergy and elite believers. In 260 Shapur I captured him after the battle of Edessa, an unprecedented humiliation; later stories of his treatment are propagandistic.

Senate and historical legacy: Captivity destroyed his authority but not the Empire. The Senate could do little as military catastrophe and regional breakaways transformed rule.

Gallienus

253-268 | Valerianic

Accession and setting: Co-emperor from 253 and sole ruler after Valerian's capture, Gallienus faced invasions, rebellions, plague, and the separation of the Gallic and Palmyrene realms.

Government and contributions: He defeated several usurpers and invaders, favored mobile cavalry reserves, promoted experienced equestrian officers, ended Valerian's persecution of Christians, and supported a cultural revival associated with Plotinus.

Controversies and conflict: The loss of provinces and rapid rebellions damaged his ancient reputation. Excluding senators from many legionary commands offended aristocratic writers but may have professionalized military leadership.

Senate and historical legacy: Gallienus was assassinated during the siege of a rival. Modern assessments often see an innovative ruler who preserved the imperial core under extraordinary pressure.

Claudius II Gothicus

268-270 | Illyrian military emperor

Accession and setting: Claudius succeeded after Gallienus' murder, probably with support from senior officers.

Government and contributions: He won a major victory over Gothic forces at Naissus and defeated the Alamanni, stabilizing the Balkans and Italy.

Controversies and conflict: His role in the conspiracy against Gallienus is uncertain. The Empire remained divided, and victory could not immediately recover Palmyra or the Gallic realm.

Senate and historical legacy: Claudius died in an epidemic and was deified. Constantine later claimed descent from him, turning a short successful reign into dynastic capital.

Quintillus

270 | Illyrian interlude

Accession and setting: Claudius' brother Quintillus was recognized in Italy and by the Senate after Claudius' death.

Government and contributions: He attempted to maintain the dynasty and command forces in northern Italy.

Controversies and conflict: Danubian troops proclaimed Aurelian. Accounts differ on whether Quintillus was killed or committed suicide after support collapsed.

Senate and historical legacy: His extremely brief reign highlights the Senate's limited ability to make its preferred candidate effective without the principal field army.

Aurelian

270-275 | Restorer of the World

Accession and setting: A Danubian cavalry commander, Aurelian was proclaimed by troops and rapidly defeated rivals.

Government and contributions: He repelled Germanic invasions, built the Aurelian Walls around Rome, reconquered the Palmyrene and Gallic breakaway empires, reformed coinage, strengthened the solar cult, and adopted the title Restitutor Orbis, "restorer of the world."

Controversies and conflict: Campaigns were harsh, the second capture of Palmyra brought destruction, and monetary reform generated unrest including a violent mint workers' revolt. His discipline made officers fear punishment.

Senate and historical legacy: A forged accusation prompted staff officers to assassinate him. Aurelian restored territorial unity and prepared the more centralized monarchy of the Tetrarchy.

Tacitus

275-276 | Senatorial interlude

Accession and setting: After Aurelian's murder, the elderly senator Tacitus became emperor, with sources emphasizing senatorial selection although army approval remained essential.

Government and contributions: He campaigned in Asia Minor against invaders and tried to honor Aurelian while presenting a dignified partnership with the Senate.

Controversies and conflict: He died within months, from illness or violence. Claims that he restored full senatorial government are later exaggeration.

Senate and historical legacy: Tacitus' reign was remembered as a brief revival of senatorial choice, but strategic power remained with mobile armies.

Florian

276 | Military claimant

Accession and setting: Tacitus' half-brother Florian was recognized in the West without awaiting broad army consensus.

Government and contributions: He continued operations against invaders in Asia Minor.

Controversies and conflict: Eastern troops proclaimed Probus. Florian's forces, weakened by climate and delay, killed him after a short standoff.

Senate and historical legacy: His fall again showed that hereditary connection and senatorial acceptance could not overcome a rival with stronger regional military support.

Probus

276-282 | Illyrian military emperor

Accession and setting: Eastern troops acclaimed the experienced commander Probus, who defeated Florian and gained general recognition.

Government and contributions: He campaigned successfully on the Rhine and Danube, resettled groups within the Empire, suppressed usurpers, repaired agriculture and infrastructure, and used soldiers on public works.

Controversies and conflict: Constant campaigning and labor discipline bred resentment. Some resettlement policies carried long-term risks and ancient praise may exaggerate his plan to make armies unnecessary.

Senate and historical legacy: Soldiers killed Probus near Sirmium. He was one of the most capable restorers before Diocletian, but could not solve the political danger posed by his own army.

Carus

282-283 | Caran dynasty

Accession and setting: Praetorian prefect Carus was proclaimed after Probus' murder and associated his sons Carinus and Numerian with rule.

Government and contributions: He defeated Sarmatians and launched a successful Persian invasion, capturing Ctesiphon.

Controversies and conflict: Carus died suddenly in the East, traditionally said to have been struck by lightning, though illness or murder is possible. The campaign ended without durable settlement.

Senate and historical legacy: His reign demonstrated revived Roman offensive capacity but left succession divided between sons in distant theaters.

Numerian

283-284 | Caran dynasty

Accession and setting: Carus' younger son governed the eastern army and began withdrawal from Persia.

Government and contributions: He preserved orderly retreat after his father's death and was praised for literary refinement.

Controversies and conflict: Numerian died secretly in his litter; the prefect Aper concealed the death until decomposition revealed it. The army proclaimed Diocletian, who publicly killed Aper.

Senate and historical legacy: His mysterious death furnished the dramatic origin story of the Tetrarchic founder.

Carinus

283-285 | Caran dynasty

Accession and setting: Carus' elder son ruled the West, defeated challengers, and held the legitimate dynastic title after his father and brother died.

Government and contributions: He campaigned effectively and met Diocletian's army in the Balkans, apparently winning or at least avoiding clear defeat at the Margus.

Controversies and conflict: Hostile sources portray sexual excess and cruelty, likely colored by Diocletianic propaganda. Carinus was killed by his own officers during or after battle.

Senate and historical legacy: His death left Diocletian sole ruler. As with many defeated emperors, moral condemnation served to validate the victor.

Sources and further reading: Cassius Dio; Herodian; Historia Augusta (used critically); inscriptions, papyri, coinage; Dexippus fragments; Clifford Ando, Imperial Rome AD 193 to 284; David Potter, The Roman Empire at Bay; Pat Southern, The Roman Empire from Severus to Constantine.

CHAPTER 18

Diocletian, the Tetrarchy, and Constantine

A new imperial system, civil war, Christian patronage, and Constantinople

Diocletian responded to third-century instability by multiplying rulers, provinces, capitals, and administrative layers. The Tetrarchy was intended to make imperial presence permanent on several frontiers and to provide orderly succession through senior Augusti and junior Caesars. It collapsed into civil wars, but many reforms endured. Constantine reunited the Empire and redirected its religious and geopolitical future.

Historical setting

Late Roman emperors did not simply become “oriental despots.” Their more ceremonial monarchy answered practical needs: rulers traveled with courts and armies, issued law across vast distances, and distinguished sacred imperial authority from ordinary office. The Senate remained prestigious but no longer formed the government’s exclusive personnel pool.

Diocletian

284-305 | Tetrarchy

Accession and setting: Proclaimed by the eastern army after Numerian’s death, Diocletian defeated Carinus and gradually built a college of emperors.

Government and contributions: He appointed Maximian as co-Augustus and Constantius and Galerius as Caesars; reorganized provinces and dioceses; expanded taxation and bureaucracy; separated many civil and military duties; strengthened frontiers; reformed coinage; and issued the Edict on Maximum Prices during inflation.

Controversies and conflict: Tax demands were heavy, price controls were difficult to enforce, and from 303 the Great Persecution attacked churches, scriptures, clergy, and Christian civil rights with uneven regional intensity. Court ceremony and imperial distance offended later nostalgic accounts.

Senate and historical legacy: Diocletian voluntarily abdicated in 305, an extraordinary act meant to prove that the system outranked the individual. His retirement could not prevent civil war, but his administrative and fiscal structures defined late Roman government.

Maximian

286-305; 306-308; claimant to 310 | Tetrarchy

Accession and setting: Diocletian elevated his fellow officer Maximian to govern the West, where rebellions, piracy, and frontier threats demanded a resident emperor.

Government and contributions: He suppressed the Bagaudae, campaigned on the Rhine and in Africa, and shared the Tetrarchic reconstruction of defenses and taxation.

Controversies and conflict: After abdicating with Diocletian, Maximian repeatedly returned to politics, first supporting his son Maxentius and later attempting to displace Constantine. His shifting alliances undermined the ideal of orderly retirement.

Senate and historical legacy: Forced to die after plotting against Constantine, Maximian was briefly condemned and later rehabilitated through Constantine’s marriage connection. His career exposed the power of dynastic loyalty within an anti-dynastic system.

Constantius I Chlorus

293-306 | Tetrarchy

Accession and setting: Appointed Caesar under Maximian, Constantius recovered territories from the breakaway ruler Carausius and governed Gaul and Britain. He became western Augustus in 305.

Government and contributions: He restored Britain to the Empire, campaigned successfully on the Rhine, rebuilt cities, and enforced the persecution of Christians less aggressively than colleagues, at least in later tradition.

Controversies and conflict: His earlier separation from Helena and marriage into the Tetrarchic dynasty were political arrangements. His death at York created the succession crisis the Tetrarchy was designed to prevent.

Senate and historical legacy: His troops acclaimed his son Constantine. Constantius' military reputation and comparatively mild memory became pillars of Constantinian legitimacy.

Galerius

293-311 | Tetrarchy

Accession and setting: Diocletian's Caesar in the East, Galerius became Augustus in 305 and tried to control the succession by appointing loyal juniors.

Government and contributions: He defeated the Sasanian king Narseh, secured favorable eastern terms, fortified the Danube, and helped sustain the Tetrarchic administrative system.

Controversies and conflict: Galerius was a principal advocate of the Great Persecution in hostile Christian sources. His exclusion of Constantine and Maxentius from the planned succession triggered competing acclamations and civil war.

Senate and historical legacy: Gravely ill, he issued an edict of toleration in 311 asking Christians to pray for the state. His death removed the senior figure capable of enforcing Tetrarchic hierarchy.

Severus II

305-307 | Tetrarchy

Accession and setting: Galerius promoted Severus from Caesar to western Augustus after Constantius' death, bypassing Constantine's claim to senior rank.

Government and contributions: He represented the intended merit-based Tetrarchic succession and was charged with suppressing Maxentius in Rome.

Controversies and conflict: His troops, many formerly loyal to Maximian, deserted. Severus surrendered and was imprisoned and killed.

Senate and historical legacy: His failure showed that formal appointment meant little when dynastic candidates controlled established loyalties and strategic cities.

Maximinus II Daia

305-313 | Tetrarchy

Accession and setting: A nephew of Galerius, Maximinus became Caesar in the East and later claimed the rank of Augustus.

Government and contributions: He defended eastern frontiers, administered Syria and Egypt, and competed vigorously for territories after Galerius' death.

Controversies and conflict: He intensified anti-Christian measures in his regions and sponsored petitions supporting traditional cult. War with Licinius ended in defeat, retreat, and death.

Senate and historical legacy: Christian narratives made him a persecuting tyrant, but his reign also reflects the political use of civic religion and the fragmentation of Tetrarchic legitimacy.

Maxentius

306-312 | Dynastic claimant in Italy

Accession and setting: The people and Praetorians at Rome proclaimed Maximian's son Maxentius after the Tetrarchic succession marginalized him. He controlled Italy and Africa for six years and used the title Augustus.

Government and contributions: He built extensively in Rome, including the great basilica later associated with Constantine, and promoted the city's ancient prestige.

Controversies and conflict: He faced fiscal pressure, loss and recovery of Africa, internal unrest, and propaganda portraying him as a tyrant. His refusal to confront Constantine until the invasion of Italy proved strategically costly.

Senate and historical legacy: Maxentius drowned after defeat at the Milvian Bridge. Though omitted from lists written by victors, he was a functioning Roman emperor in his territories and a major participant in the imperial succession.

Licinius

308-324 | Tetrarchic successor

Accession and setting: Diocletian and Galerius elevated Licinius at the conference of Carnuntum. He later defeated Maximinus Daia and shared the Empire with Constantine.

Government and contributions: With Constantine he issued the 313 agreement commonly called the Edict of Milan, restoring confiscated Christian property and affirming religious liberty. He governed the East and fought Persia and frontier peoples.

Controversies and conflict: Relations with Constantine deteriorated into wars in 316-317 and 324. Later Constantinian sources accuse him of renewed persecution; the scale and motive are debated and shaped by victor's propaganda.

Senate and historical legacy: Defeated, spared, and then executed, Licinius was condemned in memory. His fall allowed Constantine to rule the entire Empire.

Constantine I the Great

306-337 | Constantinian

Accession and setting: Acclaimed by his father's army at York, Constantine moved through two decades of civil war, defeating Maxentius in 312 and Licinius in 324.

Government and contributions: He patronized Christianity, convened the Council of Nicaea, restored church property, endowed bishops, issued the solidus gold coin, restructured armies and administration, and founded Constantinople as an imperial capital. He also enacted laws on family, status, and religion and built extensively.

Controversies and conflict: He executed his son Crispus and wife Fausta under obscure circumstances, fought repeated civil wars, and used coercion alongside toleration in church disputes. His conversion's timing and personal theology remain debated, though his patronage is undeniable.

Senate and historical legacy: Constantine created a second Senate at Constantinople and made Christian imperial rule durable without abolishing traditional cult at once. His reign redirected Roman state identity and the geography of power.

Constantine II

337-340 | Constantinian

Accession and setting: One of Constantine's three surviving sons, Constantine II received Gaul, Britain, and Spain after a dynastic purge and division of the Empire.

Government and contributions: He defended western frontiers and claimed seniority based on age and earlier rank.

Controversies and conflict: Dissatisfied with the division, he invaded the territory of his brother Constans and was killed in an ambush near Aquileia.

Senate and historical legacy: His brief reign showed that multiple Augusti required agreed boundaries and hierarchy; blood relationship alone did not secure cooperation.

Constans

337-350 | Constantinian

Accession and setting: Constans received Italy, Africa, and the Balkans and absorbed Constantine II's lands after defeating him.

Government and contributions: He campaigned successfully on the Danube and visited Britain, supported Nicene bishops against eastern opponents, and maintained the western state for a decade.

Controversies and conflict: Sources accuse him of favoritism, financial pressure, and sexual misconduct, charges that may reflect rebel propaganda. The usurper Magnentius won broad military support, and Constans was killed while fleeing.

Senate and historical legacy: His fall initiated a destructive civil war that weakened frontier armies and left Constantius II sole ruler.

Constantius II

337-361 | Constantinian

Accession and setting: Constantine's longest-surviving son ruled the East from 337 and became sole emperor after defeating Magnentius in 353.

Government and contributions: He resisted Sasanian pressure, managed complex Danubian and western crises, expanded court administration, visited Rome ceremonially, and actively sponsored a non-Nicene form of Christian unity through councils and appointments.

Controversies and conflict: The massacre of relatives after Constantine's death benefited the brothers. Civil war against Magnentius was costly, court eunuchs and informers drew criticism, and religious coercion alienated Nicene and pagan writers. His relationship with his cousin Julian collapsed into rivalry.

Senate and historical legacy: Constantius used the Senate ceremonially but ruled through a mobile court and specialized bureaucracy. He died before fighting Julian, preventing another civil war.

Julian

361-363 | Constantinian

Accession and setting: A surviving nephew of Constantine, Julian was made Caesar in Gaul, where victories over Alamanni won army loyalty. Troops proclaimed him Augustus during tension with Constantius.

Government and contributions: He reduced court expense, encouraged municipal administration, wrote philosophical and satirical works, and attempted to restore and reorganize traditional cult while allowing exiled Christian factions to return.

Controversies and conflict: Julian excluded Christians from teaching classical literature and favored pagan institutions, policies seen as discriminatory even without mass persecution. His ambitious invasion of Persia ended in retreat and his death from a wound.

Senate and historical legacy: Known as "the Apostate" in Christian tradition, Julian was admired by some pagans as a philosopher-ruler. His failure showed that imperial sponsorship had already changed the religious landscape beyond easy reversal.

Jovian

363-364 | Post-Constantinian transition

Accession and setting: After Julian's death in Persia, the army selected the guard officer Jovian to lead a dangerous retreat.

Government and contributions: He secured the army's survival, restored privileges to Nicene Christianity, and reestablished a workable court after Julian's abrupt death.

Controversies and conflict: The peace ceded territories and the fortress of Nisibis to Persia, causing lasting criticism despite the army's vulnerable position. Jovian died unexpectedly before reaching Constantinople.

Senate and historical legacy: His short reign ended Constantine's dynasty and demonstrated the army's capacity to choose a compromise emperor during emergency.

Sources and further reading: Lactantius, *On the Deaths of the Persecutors*; Eusebius, *Life of Constantine and Church History*; *Panegyrici Latini*; Ammianus Marcellinus; Zosimus; legal codes; Timothy Barnes, *Constantine and Eusebius*; Roger Rees, *Diocletian and the Tetrarchy*; Noel Lenski, *The Cambridge Companion to the Age of Constantine*.

CHAPTER 19

Valentinians and Theodosians

Christian empire, Gothic settlement, divided courts, and the permanent partition of imperial government

After Jovian, senior officers selected Valentinian I, who chose his brother Valens as eastern co-emperor. The two-court system became normal: one Roman Empire, but with emperors, armies, fiscal administrations, and capitals divided by region. Religious conflict, frontier migration, and civil wars intensified, culminating in Theodosius I's brief reunification and the division between his sons.

Historical setting

The conventional date 395 marks not a legal division into two foreign states but the death of the last emperor to rule both halves personally. Eastern and Western courts continued to issue laws in the name of colleagues, negotiate marriages, and claim a common Roman order, even while their interests diverged.

Valentinian I

364-375 | Valentinianic

Accession and setting: Civil and military leaders selected Valentinian after Jovian's death. He appointed his brother Valens to rule the East and retained the West.

Government and contributions: He strengthened Rhine and Danube defenses, campaigned against Alamanni and other groups, improved military infrastructure, restrained some provincial abuses, and founded a dynasty by elevating his son Gratian.

Controversies and conflict: Heavy taxation and fierce anger shaped his reputation; Ammianus condemns some cruel officials and executions. Religious policy generally tolerated divisions among Christians in the West while defending state order.

Senate and historical legacy: Valentinian died after collapsing during an angry audience. His robust frontier monarchy relied less on Rome's Senate than on Trier, Milan, generals, and mobile administration.

Valens

364-378 | Valentinianic

Accession and setting: Valentinian's younger brother received the East despite limited prior experience and survived the revolt of Procopius.

Government and contributions: He campaigned against Goths, managed Persia and Armenia, supported Homoean Christianity, built an aqueduct at Constantinople, and maintained eastern finances.

Controversies and conflict: His religious interventions exiled Nicene bishops. Most consequentially, Roman authorities mishandled the admission of Gothic refugees fleeing the Huns, provoking revolt. Valens attacked before western reinforcements arrived and died in the catastrophic battle of Adrianople.

Senate and historical legacy: Adrianople destroyed a major field army but not the Empire. Valens became a cautionary figure for poor coordination, corruption, and battlefield impatience.

Gratian

367-383 | Valentinianic

Accession and setting: Valentinian I elevated his son Gratian as a child co-emperor; he inherited the West in 375 while the army also proclaimed his young half-brother Valentinian II.

Government and contributions: Gratian appointed Theodosius to the East after Adrianople, won frontier successes, and increasingly supported Nicene Christianity. He declined the traditional pontifical title and removed state support from some pagan institutions, including the Altar of Victory.

Controversies and conflict: Favor toward Alan troops and distance from sections of the western army contributed to Magnus Maximus' revolt. Gratian was captured and killed.

Senate and historical legacy: His religious policy accelerated the Christianization of public authority and sharpened conflict with traditionalist senators led by Symmachus.

Valentinian II

375-392 | Valentinianic

Accession and setting: Proclaimed at age four by Danubian officers, Valentinian II ruled nominally in Italy under his mother Justina, then under the dominance of powerful generals and Theodosius.

Government and contributions: His court preserved western legitimacy through the civil wars against Magnus Maximus and supported legal administration from Milan and Vienne.

Controversies and conflict: Conflict with Bishop Ambrose over churches exposed the weakness of a young Arian-leaning court. Later the general Arbogast controlled military power. Valentinian was found hanged; suicide or murder remains disputed.

Senate and historical legacy: His death allowed the pagan scholar Eugenius to be raised by Arbogast, triggering Theodosius' final civil war.

Theodosius I

379-395 | Theodosian

Accession and setting: Gratian appointed the Spanish general Theodosius after Adrianople to rebuild eastern defenses.

Government and contributions: He settled Gothic groups within the Empire, defended the Balkans, made Nicene Christianity the official doctrinal standard of imperial government, convened the Council of Constantinople, defeated Magnus Maximus and Eugenius, and briefly reunited East and West.

Controversies and conflict: The Gothic settlement's terms are debated and did not eliminate autonomous military leadership. In 390 imperial troops massacred inhabitants of Thessalonica; Bishop Ambrose compelled public penance. Laws against sacrifice and heresy linked state coercion to religious unity. His civil wars consumed Roman armies.

Senate and historical legacy: Theodosius was the last ruler to govern both halves. He left Arcadius in the East and Honorius in the West, creating dynastic continuity but entrusting young emperors to competing courts and generals.

Arcadius

383/395-408 | Theodosian East

Accession and setting: Theodosius elevated Arcadius as a child, and he became senior eastern emperor in 395 from Constantinople.

Government and contributions: His government preserved the wealthy eastern tax base, managed Gothic forces and court factions, and continued legal and Christian institutional development.

Controversies and conflict: Ministers Rufinus, Eutropius, the empress Eudoxia, and the praetorian prefect Anthemius dominated policy. Conflict with John Chrysostom and rivalry with the western court damaged his image as passive and weak.

Senate and historical legacy: Despite court turmoil, the Eastern Empire remained structurally resilient. Arcadius transmitted an intact throne to his young son Theodosius II.

Honorius

393/395-423 | Theodosian West

Accession and setting: Theodosius made Honorius co-emperor as a child; after 395 the general Stilicho governed much of the West in his name.

Government and contributions: The regime defeated several invasions, moved the court to defensible Ravenna, maintained law and administration, and survived repeated usurpations longer than its failures suggest.

Controversies and conflict: Honorius approved Stilicho's execution in 408, followed by violence against soldiers' families that drove many to Alaric. Visigoths sacked Rome in 410, Britain slipped from control, and Vandals, Sueves, and Alans entered the western provinces. Court intrigue repeatedly sacrificed capable commanders.

Senate and historical legacy: The Senate negotiated during Rome's sieges but could not direct imperial strategy. Honorius' long reign became synonymous with western paralysis, though regional fragmentation had many causes beyond the emperor's personality.

Theodosius II

402-450 | Theodosian East

Accession and setting: Crowned as a child under Arcadius, Theodosius II ruled for forty-eight years, assisted by officials and his sister Pulcheria.

Government and contributions: His reign produced the Theodosian Walls of Constantinople, the Theodosian Code, educational institutions, diplomacy with steppe powers, and councils central to Christian doctrinal disputes.

Controversies and conflict: Large payments to Attila drew criticism; court factions and the conflict surrounding the Council of Ephesus created religious division. The loss of Africa in the West proceeded while eastern aid was limited and sometimes unsuccessful.

Senate and historical legacy: Long institutional continuity under a personally unmartial emperor demonstrates the strength of the eastern court, bureaucracy, capital, and fiscal system.

Constantius III

421 | Theodosian West

Accession and setting: A successful general under Honorius, Constantius defeated usurpers, contained Visigoths, and married Galla Placidia. He was elevated as co-emperor shortly before his death.

Government and contributions: He restored much of western political unity after the crises of 407-418 and negotiated settlements that placed federate forces within imperial strategy.

Controversies and conflict: The eastern court initially refused to recognize his imperial elevation, while his growing dominance strained relations with Galla Placidia. He died after only months as Augustus.

Senate and historical legacy: Constantius' career shows how the office of magister militum became the practical route to power in the fifth-century West. His son Valentinian III inherited the dynasty.

Valentinian III

425-455 | Theodosian West

Accession and setting: After Honorius' death and the usurpation of John, the eastern court installed the child Valentinian III, with his mother Galla Placidia as regent.

Government and contributions: Under the general Aetius, the West balanced Visigoths, Franks, Burgundians, and Huns and checked Attila at the Catalaunian Plains in 451. Lawmaking and court institutions continued from Ravenna.

Controversies and conflict: Vandals seized Africa, depriving the West of revenue. Rival generals fought civil wars; Valentinian personally killed Aetius in 454 and was assassinated by Aetius' associates in 455. His personal political capacity appears limited in most sources.

Senate and historical legacy: His death ended the Theodosian dynasty in the West and removed the legitimacy that had held competing military and senatorial coalitions together.

Sources and further reading: Ammianus Marcellinus; Themistius; Libanius; Symmachus; Ambrose; ecclesiastical historians; Theodosian Code; Zosimus; Noel Lenski, *Failure of Empire*; John Matthews, *Western Aristocracies*; Neil McLynn, *Ambrose of Milan*.

CHAPTER 20

The Last Western Emperors

Vandals, generals, Ricimer, Eastern intervention, and the end of the imperial office in Italy

After Valentinian III, western emperors rose through marriage, senatorial status, military acclamation, Germanic commanders, or appointment from Constantinople. The Empire still possessed law, taxation, diplomacy, armies, cities, and a Roman Senate, but lost control of major revenue regions. Powerful generals such as Ricimer made and unmade emperors while lacking the dynastic and cultural position to take the title securely for themselves.

Historical setting

The “fall” was uneven. Roman government continued in parts of Gaul into the 480s, in Dalmatia under Julius Nepos, and in Italy under Odoacer and the Ostrogoths. The disappearance of a western Augustus was a constitutional outcome of territorial and military transformation, not a single-day extinction of Roman society.

Marcian

450-457 | Eastern emperor

Accession and setting: The soldier and official Marcian married Pulcheria after Theodosius II’s death and gained army, court, and senatorial support in Constantinople.

Government and contributions: He stopped regular tribute to the Huns, stabilized eastern finances, and convened the Council of Chalcedon, whose definition of Christ’s nature profoundly shaped Christianity.

Controversies and conflict: Chalcedon caused lasting resistance in Egypt, Syria, and Armenia. Marcian gave limited aid to the collapsing western court and did not prevent the Vandal sack of Rome.

Senate and historical legacy: His reign demonstrates the eastern state’s growing ability to choose rulers through court and army consensus while maintaining an active Constantinopolitan Senate.

Petronius Maximus

455 | Western emperor

Accession and setting: A wealthy Roman senator, Petronius Maximus seized power after Valentinian III’s murder and forced the imperial widow Licinia Eudoxia into marriage.

Government and contributions: He obtained senatorial recognition and attempted to found legitimacy through marriage and appointment of his son.

Controversies and conflict: His possible role in Valentinian’s assassination, coercive marriage, and cancellation of a Vandal marriage alliance helped precipitate crisis. When Geiseric’s fleet approached, Maximus failed to organize defense and was killed by a crowd while fleeing.

Senate and historical legacy: His seventy-five-day reign ended as Vandals entered Rome. Pope Leo negotiated, but the city endured a systematic two-week sack.

Avitus

455-456 | Western emperor

Accession and setting: A Gallic senator and diplomat, Avitus was proclaimed with Visigothic support after the Vandal sack and accepted by the Roman Senate with reluctance.

Government and contributions: He used Visigothic forces against Sueves in Spain and tried to unite Gallic aristocrats with the Italian government.

Controversies and conflict: Italy resented his Gallic base and the costs of his army. The generals Ricimer and Majorian defeated him; he was deposed and made bishop, then died under uncertain circumstances.

Senate and historical legacy: Avitus shows how regional aristocracies still envisioned a Roman Empire, but disagreed over which region and military coalition should control its court.

Majorian

457-461 | Western emperor

Accession and setting: The capable officer Majorian was elevated after military success, initially with support from Ricimer and eventual eastern recognition.

Government and contributions: He reformed taxation, protected public buildings, limited abuses, restored armies, campaigned in Gaul and Spain, and prepared a major expedition to recover Africa from the Vandals.

Controversies and conflict: Vandal action destroyed or captured his fleet in Spain, ending the campaign. Majorian's laws reveal severe fiscal and demographic strain as well as attempts to curb elite evasion.

Senate and historical legacy: Ricimer arrested and executed him after his return. Majorian is often judged the last western emperor with a plausible program for territorial restoration.

Libius Severus

461-465 | Ricimerian West

Accession and setting: Ricimer elevated the senator Libius Severus after Majorian's death. The Eastern emperor Leo I did not recognize him.

Government and contributions: His government maintained Italy, issued laws and coins, and managed relations with western military groups under Ricimer's dominance.

Controversies and conflict: Lack of eastern recognition, loss of Gaul to Aegidius' independent command, Vandal raids, and reliance on Ricimer limited authority. His death may have been natural; poisoning is unproven.

Senate and historical legacy: His reign is frequently dismissed as puppet rule, but it preserved the legal shell of western government during diplomatic deadlock.

Leo I

457-474 | Eastern Leonid

Accession and setting: The general Aspar helped elevate Leo, a military officer without dynastic claim, through coronation at Constantinople.

Government and contributions: Leo cultivated Isaurian counterweights to Aspar, strengthened eastern autonomy, sponsored orthodox Christianity, and launched a massive joint expedition against the Vandals in 468.

Controversies and conflict: The African expedition failed catastrophically at enormous cost. Leo later killed Aspar and his son, provoking unrest and revealing the violence of court emancipation from kingmakers.

Senate and historical legacy: Leo was the first emperor crowned by the patriarch in a ceremony that helped shape later Christian monarchy. His appointments directly determined several western reigns.

Anthemius

467-472 | Eastern-appointed West

Accession and setting: Leo I sent the distinguished eastern general and son-in-law Anthemius to Italy as western emperor, hoping to unite both courts against the Vandals.

Government and contributions: He brought eastern resources, campaigned in Gaul through subordinates, patronized culture, and joined the enormous 468 naval expedition to recover Africa.

Controversies and conflict: The expedition's failure destroyed resources. Religious and cultural tensions complicated his rule in Italy, while rivalry with Ricimer escalated into civil war. Rome endured siege and fighting before Anthemius was killed.

Senate and historical legacy: Anthemius was the last western emperor backed by a major coordinated eastern restoration project. His defeat marked the failure of cooperation on imperial scale.

Olybrius

472 | Western emperor

Accession and setting: A senator connected by marriage to the Theodosian and Vandal royal families, Olybrius was in Italy during Ricimer's war against Anthemius and was proclaimed emperor.

Government and contributions: His dynastic links potentially offered a diplomatic bridge to the Vandals, and he maintained government after the destructive siege of Rome.

Controversies and conflict: His elevation was inseparable from Ricimer's rebellion. Both Ricimer and Olybrius died within months, leaving Italy without stable military or dynastic leadership.

Senate and historical legacy: Olybrius' short reign illustrates how marriage connections remained a form of legitimacy even when effective power belonged to generals.

Glycerius

473-474 | Western emperor

Accession and setting: The Burgundian commander Gundobad elevated the palace official Glycerius after a period without a western emperor.

Government and contributions: He appears to have redirected or negotiated with invading groups in Italy and issued measures against religious accusations.

Controversies and conflict: Leo I and then Zeno refused recognition and appointed Julius Nepos. Lacking a comparable army, Glycerius surrendered and became bishop of Salona.

Senate and historical legacy: His peaceful deposition contrasts with many successions and shows the eastern court's continued claim to authorize western emperors.

Julius Nepos

474-475; claimant to 480 | Western emperor recognized by the East

Accession and setting: An imperial relative and ruler in Dalmatia, Julius Nepos invaded Italy with eastern support, deposed Glycerius, and was recognized as western Augustus.

Government and contributions: He negotiated with Visigoths in Gaul, appointed the general Orestes, and represented the last serious attempt to maintain an eastern-backed western government.

Controversies and conflict: Orestes revolted and drove Nepos back to Dalmatia in 475. Nepos continued to claim the western title and was recognized by Zeno until his murder in 480.

Senate and historical legacy: Legally, many historians regard Nepos rather than Romulus Augustulus as the last Western Roman emperor. His survival complicates the symbolic date 476.

Leo II

474 | Eastern Leonid

Accession and setting: Leo I's young grandson was elevated as Caesar and Augustus and inherited the eastern throne.

Government and contributions: He crowned his father Zeno as co-emperor, linking the Leonid dynasty to Isaurian military support.

Controversies and conflict: Leo II died after only months, probably from illness, though later rumor alleged foul play.

Senate and historical legacy: His death left Zeno as sole emperor and made dynastic marriage the basis of eastern legitimacy.

Zeno

474-475; 476-491 | Eastern Leonid/Isaurian

Accession and setting: An Isaurian general married to Leo I's daughter Ariadne, Zeno became co-emperor under his son Leo II and sole ruler after the child's death.

Government and contributions: He survived revolts, managed Ostrogothic leaders through shifting titles and settlements, issued the Henotikon in an effort to reduce Christian division, and received the western insignia after Odoacer deposed Romulus.

Controversies and conflict: His Isaurian background drew Constantinopolitan hostility. Basiliscus expelled him temporarily, and religious compromise alienated both Chalcedonian and anti-Chalcedonian groups.

Senate and historical legacy: Zeno recognized Julius Nepos in theory while granting Odoacer patrician rank and later sent Theoderic to Italy. His reign connected the end of the western court to the rise of Ostrogothic Italy.

Basiliscus

475-476 | Eastern usurpation

Accession and setting: Leo I's brother-in-law and commander of the failed 468 Vandal expedition, Basiliscus exploited opposition to Zeno and seized Constantinople.

Government and contributions: He attempted to secure religious support from opponents of Chalcedon and elevated his son Marcus.

Controversies and conflict: His earlier naval disaster, unpopular fiscal measures, a major city fire, and divisive religious policy eroded support. Zeno returned, and Basiliscus surrendered under a promise reportedly violated when he and his family died in confinement.

Senate and historical legacy: Basiliscus' brief rule overlapped Orestes' regime in Italy, illustrating simultaneous instability at both imperial courts.

Romulus Augustulus

475-476 | Last emperor ruling in Italy

Accession and setting: The general Orestes deposed Julius Nepos and placed his young son Romulus on the throne. The eastern court did not recognize him.

Government and contributions: Coins and documents maintained imperial forms, but Orestes controlled the regime. The boy's names - Romulus and Augustus - later gave his fall irresistible symbolism.

Controversies and conflict: Orestes refused land demands from federate troops led by Odoacer. The troops rebelled, killed Orestes, and deposed Romulus. Because of his youth, Odoacer spared him and granted an allowance; his later life is obscure.

Senate and historical legacy: Romulus' deposition on 4 September 476 is the conventional end of the Western Roman Empire. Julius Nepos still claimed the title, the Senate remained, and Roman government continued under a king, so the date is a marker rather than an absolute ending.

Sources and further reading: Hydatius; Sidonius Apollinaris; Priscus; Jordanes; Marcellinus Comes; Procopius for later retrospective narrative; legal texts and inscriptions; Ralph Mathisen; Penny MacGeorge, Late Roman Warlords; Peter Heather; Guy Halsall.

CHAPTER 21

Usurpers, Breakaway Empires, and Contested Legitimacy

Why the official emperor list cannot tell the whole story

Calling a claimant a “usurper” is partly retrospective. A victorious rebel became a legitimate emperor; a defeated emperor could be branded a tyrant. In an empire without a fixed succession law, recognition by armies, cities, mints, courts, and fellow emperors mattered. The following figures either ruled large territories for substantial periods or exposed fundamental weaknesses in imperial control.

Sertorius

80-72 BCE - A Marian commander who built a rival Roman government in Spain with a Senate of exiles and strong local alliances. His regime demonstrates that civil-war opponents claimed to embody the Republic rather than reject it.

Pescennius Niger

193-194 - Governor of Syria, proclaimed after Pertinax. He controlled much of the East and was defeated by Septimius Severus, who then punished supporting cities.

Clodius Albinus

193-197 - Commander in Britain, first named Caesar by Severus and later proclaimed Augustus. His defeat near Lugdunum ended the final major rival to the Severan dynasty.

Postumus and the Gallic Empire

260-274 - Postumus and successors ruled Gaul, Britain, and at times Spain with their own emperors, consuls, guard, and coinage. They defended the Rhine while claiming Roman legitimacy, not separatist nationality.

Odaenathus, Zenobia, and Palmyra

260s-272 - Palmyrene rulers defended the East after Valerian’s capture and then built an autonomous imperial realm under Zenobia and her son Vaballathus. Aurelian reconquered it in two campaigns.

Carausius and Allectus

286-296 - Naval commanders who controlled Britain and parts of the Channel coast, issued sophisticated coinage, and claimed imperial equality until Constantius’ forces restored the island.

Magnentius

350-353 - An army-backed western emperor who overthrew Constans and gained senatorial and provincial support. His civil war with Constantius II culminated in the costly battle of Mursa.

Procopius

365-366 - A relative of Julian who claimed the eastern throne against Valens using dynastic associations and support at Constantinople. Betrayal by commanders ended the revolt.

Magnus Maximus

383-388 - A successful general proclaimed in Britain who killed Gratian and ruled Gaul, Britain, and Spain. Theodosius defeated him after he invaded Valentinian II's Italy.

Eugenius and Arbogast

392-394 - The Frankish general Arbogast elevated the scholar Eugenius after Valentinian II's death. Their court attracted pagan senatorial support, but the conflict with Theodosius was political as well as religious.

Constantine III

407-411 - Proclaimed in Britain during crisis, he moved to Gaul and briefly controlled much of the western prefecture. His withdrawal of troops is associated with the end of effective imperial rule in Britain.

John (Joannes)

423-425 - A senior civil official proclaimed after Honorius died. Eastern forces defeated him and installed Valentinian III, revealing Constantinople's power to determine western succession.

Sources and further reading: Herodian; Cassius Dio; Historia Augusta (used cautiously); Ammianus Marcellinus; Zosimus; John Drinkwater, *The Gallic Empire*; David Potter, *The Roman Empire at Bay*.

CHAPTER 22

After 476: The Eastern Roman Continuation

Why the Roman Empire did not simply “fall” when the Western imperial office disappeared

When Odoacer deposed Romulus Augustulus in 476, he did not announce the destruction of Roman civilization. He sent the imperial insignia to the Eastern emperor Zeno and governed Italy as king while using Roman administration and seeking imperial recognition. The Senate of Rome survived, and the emperor in Constantinople remained the senior Roman sovereign. Modern historians use “Byzantine Empire” as a convenient label, but its inhabitants called themselves Romans and their state the Roman Empire.

The Eastern Empire preserved Roman law, taxation, diplomacy, cities, Christianity, and imperial government while changing language, military organization, and political culture. Greek gradually became the dominant language of administration, but Roman identity remained central. The sequence below highlights rulers who transformed this continuing empire; it is not a complete list of every Eastern emperor.

Anastasius I

491-518

A civilian official chosen through court consensus, Anastasius reformed coinage and taxation and left a huge treasury surplus. Religious policy and the Isaurian War caused conflict, but his fiscal foundation strengthened the sixth-century state.

Justin I and Justinian I

518-565

Justin’s accession brought his nephew Justinian to power. Justinian codified Roman law in the *Corpus Juris Civilis*, reconquered Africa and much of Italy, built Hagia Sophia, and survived the Nika revolt. The conquests, plague, taxation, and long wars also exhausted resources.

Maurice and Heraclius

582-641

Maurice restored finances and frontiers but was overthrown by Phocas. Heraclius defeated a massive Persian invasion, only to see Syria and Egypt lost to early Islamic armies. Greek administrative usage expanded, yet the rulers and population remained Roman in identity.

Leo III and the Isaurian dynasty

717-802

Leo III survived the great Arab siege of Constantinople and reorganized law and defense. Iconoclasm produced deep religious controversy and later hostile narratives, while the state stabilized in a smaller medieval form.

Basil II

976-1025

Basil II defeated major aristocratic revolts and the Bulgarian Empire, strengthened imperial authority, and left the medieval Roman state at a peak of military power. His harsh image partly reflects later legend.

Alexios I Komnenos

1081-1118

Facing invasion and fiscal collapse, Alexios rebuilt armies through family networks and diplomacy. His request for western aid helped precipitate the First Crusade, creating cooperation and tension between Latin and Roman Christian worlds.

The Fourth Crusade and the restoration

1204-1261

Crusaders captured and brutally sacked Constantinople in 1204, establishing a Latin Empire. Roman successor states survived at Nicaea, Epirus, and Trebizond. Michael VIII Palaiologos recovered Constantinople in 1261, but the restored empire was poorer and territorially constrained.

Constantine XI Palaiologos

1449-1453

The final Roman emperor defended Constantinople against Mehmed II. The city fell on 29 May 1453, and Constantine died in the fighting. This event, not 476, ended the continuous imperial government based at Constantinople.

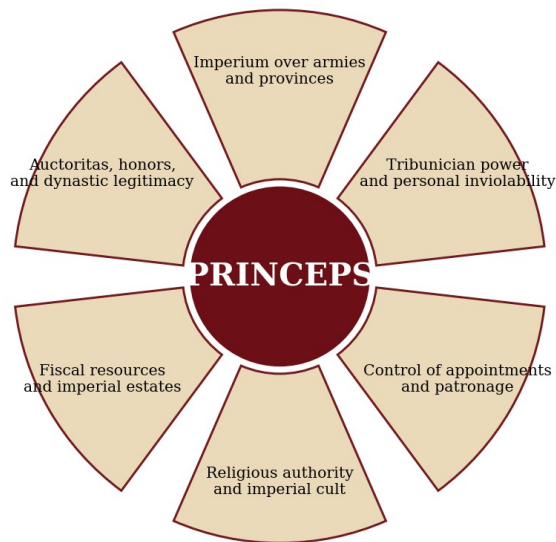
Sources and further reading: A. H. M. Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*; John Haldon, *The Empire That Would Not Die*; Judith Herrin, *Byzantium*; Anthony Kaldellis, *The New Roman Empire*; Theophanes and later Byzantine chronicles, used critically.

CHAPTER 23

What Changed - and What Endured

The Senate from sovereign city council to imperial aristocratic institution

The Emperor's Power Was a Bundle of Offices, Commands, Resources, and Prestige



Imperial authority was an accumulation of republican powers, military command, patronage, wealth, religious authority, and control of information.

The transition from Republic to Empire was not the replacement of a constitution by a single new office. Augustus accumulated powers that republican magistrates had held separately, while keeping elections, senatorial meetings, courts, priesthoods, and traditional titles. The emperor's supremacy arose because these powers were continuous, geographically vast, backed by the permanent army, and reinforced by patronage and control of appointments.

The Senate lost the ability to determine the overall direction of the state, but it did not become meaningless. Senators governed provinces, commanded legions in the early Empire, sat as judges, issued decrees, administered Rome, preserved aristocratic memory, and conferred public legitimacy. Even emperors who humiliated it usually needed senatorial personnel. In late antiquity, the body's political leverage diminished further, yet membership became an even broader status order linking wealthy families to the imperial court.

The deeper continuity was social rather than constitutional. Roman government relied on hierarchies of rank, personal patronage, public honor, legal privilege, and competition for office. The emperor stood at the summit of these relationships. A "good" emperor allowed elites to feel that their dignity and property were secure; a "bad" emperor appeared arbitrary, confiscatory, sexually transgressive, cruel, or contemptuous of status. That framework shaped ancient accounts and still colors modern reputations.

The central paradox

The Senate survived the Republic because it was not merely a legislature. It was an aristocratic council, a recruiting pool for administrators, a court of prestige, a repository of precedent, and a language of legitimacy. Those functions remained useful even after the emperor monopolized strategic decision-making.

CHAPTER 24

Complete Profile Index: Augustus to 476

Recognized emperors and co-emperors covered in this volume

The table summarizes the main profiles. It does not include every claimant who struck coins or received a local acclamation; those appear in the separate chapter on usurpers and breakaway regimes.

Emperor	Reign	Dynasty / era	Defining feature
Augustus	27 BCE-14 CE	Julio-Claudian founder	He stabilized taxation and provincial administration, professionalized the standing army, established the Praetorian Guard and military treasury, rebuilt Rome, encouraged marriage and moral legislation, sponsored literature, and oversaw expansion in Spain, the Alps, the Balkans, and Egypt.
Tiberius	14-37	Julio-Claudian	Tiberius kept finances strong, governed provinces cautiously, limited expensive expansion after Germanicus' campaigns, and often respected administrative competence.
Gaius Caligula	37-41	Julio-Claudian	He distributed gifts, restored some exiles, began major building works and aqueducts, promoted imperial cult policy in the provinces, and planned ambitious campaigns.
Claudius	41-54	Julio-Claudian	Claudius conquered Britain, annexed or reorganized client kingdoms, expanded the port at Ostia, built aqueducts, improved judicial and administrative routines, and admitted provincial elites.
Nero	54-68	Julio-Claudian	Early policies reduced some taxes and encouraged judicial restraint.
Galba	68-69	Civil war of 68-69	He attempted fiscal retrenchment, punished some Neronian agents, and refused to buy military loyalty with indiscriminate gifts.
Otho	69	Civil war of 68-69	He reconciled some Neronian supporters, tried to maintain urban order, and moved quickly against Vitellius' Rhine armies.
Vitellius	69	Civil war of 68-69	He rewarded supporters, revised some court appointments, and tried to ground his rule in the victorious German armies.
Vespasian	69-79	Flavian	He restored fiscal stability, rebuilt after civil war and fire, began the Colosseum, regularized imperial powers, expanded elite recruitment from Italy and provinces, and completed major campaigns in Judaea and Britain through his generals.
Titus	79-81	Flavian	He completed and dedicated the Colosseum, provided relief after the eruption of Vesuvius and a major fire in Rome, and cultivated clemency.
Domitian	81-96	Flavian	He strengthened frontier defenses, raised soldiers' pay, conducted campaigns on the Rhine and Danube, supported provincial administration, regulated coinage, rebuilt

Emperor	Reign	Dynasty / era	Defining feature
Nerva	96-98	Nerva-Antonine	monumental Rome, and took an active interest in justice.
Trajan	98-117	Nerva-Antonine	He recalled exiles, limited treason prosecutions, distributed land to some poor citizens, and adopted the highly respected general Trajan after a Praetorian mutiny exposed his weakness.
Hadrian	117-138	Nerva-Antonine	He conquered Dacia, annexed its resources, campaigned deep into the Parthian world, expanded roads, harbors and welfare schemes, developed Rome's Forum and markets, and promoted a cooperative image.
Antoninus Pius	138-161	Nerva-Antonine	He consolidated frontiers, built fortifications including Hadrian's Wall, traveled extensively, inspected armies, codified the praetorian edict, patronized Greek culture, and rebuilt the Pantheon.
Marcus Aurelius	161-180	Nerva-Antonine	His long reign emphasized legal administration, fiscal prudence, repair, provincial stability, and measured frontier activity.
Lucius Verus	161-169	Nerva-Antonine co-emperor	He managed the Parthian War through Verus and generals, confronted Germanic invasions along the Danube, sold palace valuables during fiscal pressure, developed law and administration, and left the philosophical Meditations.
Commodus	177/180-192	Antonine	Verus traveled east during the Parthian War while generals captured major cities and restored Roman influence in Armenia and Mesopotamia.
Pertinax	193	Post-Antonine transition	He ended the exhausting Danubian war, maintained portions of the administration, and cultivated support among soldiers and the urban populace through games and largesse.
Didius Julianus	193	Post-Antonine transition	He attempted to restore discipline, reduce extravagance, repair finances, and reverse some confiscations.
Septimius Severus	193-211	Severan	He tried to issue orders and negotiate with provincial commanders, but possessed little legitimacy beyond the Guard.
Caracalla	198/211-217	Severan	He increased soldiers' pay, permitted legal military families, strengthened frontiers, campaigned in Parthia and Britain, enlarged the imperial administration, and sponsored major building.
Geta	209-211	Severan co-emperor	The Constitutio Antoniniana of 212 granted Roman citizenship to nearly all free inhabitants of the Empire, a profound legal integration.
Macrinus	217-218	Interlude	His formal role was to preserve dynastic partnership, and coins and ceremonies advertised concord.
Elagabalus	218-222	Severan restoration	He sought peace with Parthia, attempted fiscal restraint, and reduced some new soldiers' pay while preserving rates for existing troops.
			He brought the Emesene sun god Elagabal to Rome, promoted a universal solar cult, distributed favors, and adopted his cousin Severus Alexander under pressure.

Emperor	Reign	Dynasty / era	Defining feature
Severus Alexander	222-235	Severan	His government cultivated moderation, restored senatorial participation, sponsored building, and responded to the new Sasanian Persian power and Germanic threats.
Maximinus Thrax	235-238	Barracks emperor	He campaigned energetically across the Rhine and Danube, maintaining frontier pressure at a moment of serious threat.
Gordian I and Gordian II	238	African revolt	Their revolt provided a senatorial rallying point and spread opposition to Maximinus.
Pupienus and Balbinus	238	Senatorial emperors	Pupienus' mobilization coincided with Maximinus' assassination, and the regime briefly represented collective senatorial government.
Gordian III	238-244	Gordian	His government restored symbolic unity, relied on the capable prefect Timesitheus, and launched a major campaign against Sasanian Persia that initially recovered territory.
Philip the Arab	244-249	Military emperor	He celebrated Rome's one-thousandth anniversary in 248, appointed relatives to key commands, and attempted to stabilize frontiers and finances.
Decius	249-251	Military emperor	He fought Gothic invaders, emphasized traditional Roman religion, and required inhabitants to certify sacrifice for the safety of the Empire.
Trebonianus Gallus and Volusian	251-253	Military emperors	Gallus made a difficult settlement with the Goths and faced the continuing plague and Persian pressure.
Aemilian	253	Military emperor	His only clear contribution was the restoration of military confidence on the Danube.
Valerian	253-260	Valerianic	He responded to Persian invasion, attempted to restore authority in the East, and established a practical model of geographically divided imperial labor.
Gallienus	253-268	Valerianic	He defeated several usurpers and invaders, favored mobile cavalry reserves, promoted experienced equestrian officers, ended Valerian's persecution of Christians, and supported a cultural revival associated with Plotinus.
Claudius II Gothicus	268-270	Illyrian military emperor	He won a major victory over Gothic forces at Naissus and defeated the Alamanni, stabilizing the Balkans and Italy.
Quintillus	270	Illyrian interlude	He attempted to maintain the dynasty and command forces in northern Italy.
Aurelian	270-275	Restorer of the World	He repelled Germanic invasions, built the Aurelian Walls around Rome, reconquered the Palmyrene and Gallic breakaway empires, reformed coinage, strengthened the solar cult, and adopted the title Restitutor Orbis, "restorer of the world.
Tacitus	275-276	Senatorial interlude	He campaigned in Asia Minor against invaders and tried to honor Aurelian while presenting a dignified partnership with the Senate.
Florian	276	Military claimant	He continued operations against invaders in Asia Minor.

Emperor	Reign	Dynasty / era	Defining feature
Probus	276-282	Illyrian military emperor	He campaigned successfully on the Rhine and Danube, resettled groups within the Empire, suppressed usurpers, repaired agriculture and infrastructure, and used soldiers on public works.
Carus	282-283	Caran dynasty	He defeated Sarmatians and launched a successful Persian invasion, capturing Ctesiphon.
Numerian	283-284	Caran dynasty	He preserved orderly retreat after his father's death and was praised for literary refinement.
Carinus	283-285	Caran dynasty	He campaigned effectively and met Diocletian's army in the Balkans, apparently winning or at least avoiding clear defeat at the Margus.
Diocletian	284-305	Tetrarchy	He appointed Maximian as co-Augustus and Constantius and Galerius as Caesars; reorganized provinces and dioceses; expanded taxation and bureaucracy; separated many civil and military duties; strengthened frontiers; reformed coinage; and issued the Edict on Maximum Prices during inflation.
Maximian	286-305; 306-308; claimant to 310	Tetrarchy	He suppressed the Bagaudae, campaigned on the Rhine and in Africa, and shared the Tetrarchic reconstruction of defenses and taxation.
Constantius I Chlorus	293-306	Tetrarchy	He restored Britain to the Empire, campaigned successfully on the Rhine, rebuilt cities, and enforced the persecution of Christians less aggressively than colleagues, at least in later tradition.
Galerius	293-311	Tetrarchy	He defeated the Sasanian king Narseh, secured favorable eastern terms, fortified the Danube, and helped sustain the Tetrarchic administrative system.
Severus II	305-307	Tetrarchy	He represented the intended merit-based Tetrarchic succession and was charged with suppressing Maxentius in Rome.
Maximinus II Daia	305-313	Tetrarchy	He defended eastern frontiers, administered Syria and Egypt, and competed vigorously for territories after Galerius' death.
Maxentius	306-312	Dynastic claimant in Italy	He built extensively in Rome, including the great basilica later associated with Constantine, and promoted the city's ancient prestige.
Licinius	308-324	Tetrarchic successor	With Constantine he issued the 313 agreement commonly called the Edict of Milan, restoring confiscated Christian property and affirming religious liberty.
Constantine I the Great	306-337	Constantinian	He patronized Christianity, convened the Council of Nicaea, restored church property, endowed bishops, issued the solidus gold coin, restructured armies and administration, and founded Constantinople as an imperial capital.
Constantine II	337-340	Constantinian	He defended western frontiers and claimed seniority based on age and earlier rank.
Constans	337-350	Constantinian	He campaigned successfully on the Danube and visited Britain, supported Nicene bishops against eastern

Emperor	Reign	Dynasty / era	Defining feature
Constantius II	337-361	Constantinian	opponents, and maintained the western state for a decade. He resisted Sasanian pressure, managed complex Danubian and western crises, expanded court administration, visited Rome ceremonially, and actively sponsored a non-Nicene form of Christian unity through councils and appointments.
Julian	361-363	Constantinian	He reduced court expense, encouraged municipal administration, wrote philosophical and satirical works, and attempted to restore and reorganize traditional cult while allowing exiled Christian factions to return.
Jovian	363-364	Post-Constantinian transition	He secured the army's survival, restored privileges to Nicene Christianity, and reestablished a workable court after Julian's abrupt death.
Valentinian I	364-375	Valentinianic	He strengthened Rhine and Danube defenses, campaigned against Alamanni and other groups, improved military infrastructure, restrained some provincial abuses, and founded a dynasty by elevating his son Gratian.
Valens	364-378	Valentinianic	He campaigned against Goths, managed Persia and Armenia, supported Homoean Christianity, built an aqueduct at Constantinople, and maintained eastern finances.
Gratian	367-383	Valentinianic	Gratian appointed Theodosius to the East after Adrianople, won frontier successes, and increasingly supported Nicene Christianity.
Valentinian II	375-392	Valentinianic	His court preserved western legitimacy through the civil wars against Magnus Maximus and supported legal administration from Milan and Vienne.
Theodosius I	379-395	Theodosian	He settled Gothic groups within the Empire, defended the Balkans, made Nicene Christianity the official doctrinal standard of imperial government, convened the Council of Constantinople, defeated Magnus Maximus and Eugenius, and briefly reunited East and West.
Arcadius	383/395-408	Theodosian East	His government preserved the wealthy eastern tax base, managed Gothic forces and court factions, and continued legal and Christian institutional development.
Honorius	393/395-423	Theodosian West	The regime defeated several invasions, moved the court to defensible Ravenna, maintained law and administration, and survived repeated usurpations longer than its failures suggest.
Theodosius II	402-450	Theodosian East	His reign produced the Theodosian Walls of Constantinople, the Theodosian Code, educational institutions, diplomacy with steppe powers, and councils central to Christian doctrinal disputes.
Constantius III	421	Theodosian West	He restored much of western political unity after the crises of 407-418 and negotiated settlements that placed federate forces within imperial

Emperor	Reign	Dynasty / era	Defining feature
Valentinian III	425-455	Theodosian West	strategy. Under the general Aetius, the West balanced Visigoths, Franks, Burgundians, and Huns and checked Attila at the Catalaunian Plains in 451.
Marcian	450-457	Eastern emperor	He stopped regular tribute to the Huns, stabilized eastern finances, and convened the Council of Chalcedon, whose definition of Christ's nature profoundly shaped Christianity.
Petronius Maximus	455	Western emperor	He obtained senatorial recognition and attempted to found legitimacy through marriage and appointment of his son.
Avitus	455-456	Western emperor	He used Visigothic forces against Sueves in Spain and tried to unite Gallic aristocrats with the Italian government.
Majorian	457-461	Western emperor	He reformed taxation, protected public buildings, limited abuses, restored armies, campaigned in Gaul and Spain, and prepared a major expedition to recover Africa from the Vandals.
Libius Severus	461-465	Ricimerian West	His government maintained Italy, issued laws and coins, and managed relations with western military groups under Ricimer's dominance.
Leo I	457-474	Eastern Leonid	Leo cultivated Isaurian counterweights to Aspar, strengthened eastern autonomy, sponsored orthodox Christianity, and launched a massive joint expedition against the Vandals in 468.
Anthemius	467-472	Eastern-appointed West	He brought eastern resources, campaigned in Gaul through subordinates, patronized culture, and joined the enormous 468 naval expedition to recover Africa.
Olybrius	472	Western emperor	His dynastic links potentially offered a diplomatic bridge to the Vandals, and he maintained government after the destructive siege of Rome.
Glycerius	473-474	Western emperor	He appears to have redirected or negotiated with invading groups in Italy and issued measures against religious accusations.
Julius Nepos	474-475; claimant to 480	Western emperor recognized by the East	He negotiated with Visigoths in Gaul, appointed the general Orestes, and represented the last serious attempt to maintain an eastern-backed western government.
Leo II	474	Eastern Leonid	He crowned his father Zeno as co-emperor, linking the Leonid dynasty to Isaurian military support.
Zeno	474-475; 476-491	Eastern Leonid/Isaurian	He survived revolts, managed Ostrogothic leaders through shifting titles and settlements, issued the Henotikon in an effort to reduce Christian division, and received the western insignia after Odoacer deposed Romulus.
Basiliscus	475-476	Eastern usurpation	He attempted to secure religious support from opponents of Chalcedon and elevated his son Marcus.
Romulus Augustulus	475-476	Last emperor ruling in Italy	Coins and documents maintained imperial forms, but Orestes controlled the regime.

CHAPTER 25

Appendix A: Chronology of the Senate and Roman Government

Key institutional changes from the monarchy to late antiquity

Date	Event and importance
Traditional 753 BCE	Legendary foundation of Rome; later tradition attributes the first council of “fathers” to Romulus.
Traditional 509 BCE	Expulsion of the kings and beginning of annual consulship; the precise early constitutional development is uncertain.
494 BCE	Traditional first plebeian secession and creation of tribunes of the plebs.
451-450 BCE	Traditional date of the Twelve Tables, Rome’s foundational public law code.
367 BCE	Licinio-Sextian legislation traditionally associated with plebeian access to the consulship.
287 BCE	Lex Hortensia gives plebiscites binding force for all citizens.
264-146 BCE	Punic Wars; Rome becomes dominant in the western Mediterranean and acquires major provinces.
218-201 BCE	Second Punic War; senatorial coordination, alliances, taxation, and repeated command extensions are tested by Hannibal.
186 BCE	Senate suppresses the Bacchanalian associations across Italy.
180 BCE	Lex Villia annalis regulates the sequence and likely minimum ages of magistracies.
149 BCE	Permanent extortion court established; provincial accountability becomes a major political field.
133-121 BCE	Tribunates and deaths of Tiberius and Gaius Gracchus; agrarian, judicial, grain, and citizenship disputes turn violent.
107-100 BCE	Marius’ commands and repeated consulships; veteran settlement and military politics intensify.
91-88 BCE	Social War; Rome extends citizenship across Italy.
88 BCE	Sulla becomes the first Roman commander to march his army on Rome.
82-79 BCE	Sulla’s dictatorship, proscriptions, enlargement of the Senate, and constitutional reforms.
70 BCE	Pompey and Crassus restore powers restricted from the tribunate; senatorial juries are restructured.
67-66 BCE	Extraordinary commands grant Pompey vast authority against pirates and Mithridates.
63 BCE	Cicero’s consulship and Catilinarian conspiracy; dispute over execution of citizens under emergency authority.
59 BCE	Caesar’s consulship and legislation backed by the coalition with Pompey and Crassus.
49 BCE	Caesar crosses the Rubicon; civil war against Pompey and senatorial forces.
44 BCE	Caesar becomes dictator in perpetuity and is assassinated at a Senate meeting on 15 March.
43 BCE	Second Triumvirate legally established; proscriptions and war against Caesar’s killers.
31 BCE	Octavian defeats Antony and Cleopatra at Actium.
27 BCE	First Augustan settlement; Octavian receives the name Augustus and

Date	Event and importance
	command over key provinces.
23 BCE	Second Augustan settlement; tribunician power and superior proconsular authority stabilize the Principate.
14 CE	Tiberius succeeds Augustus; hereditary expectations and constitutional ratification merge.
Early reign of Tiberius	Effective election of magistrates moves from popular assemblies to the Senate.
69	Four emperors and civil war reveal the decisive role of provincial armies.
96	Domitian assassinated; Senate condemns his memory and recognizes Nerva.
212	Caracalla grants citizenship to nearly all free inhabitants of the Empire.
235-284	Third-century political and military crisis; rapid emperors, invasions, breakaway regimes, and administrative transformation.
260s	Gallienus increasingly excludes senators from legionary command, accelerating equestrian military careers.
284-305	Diocletian creates the Tetrarchy and reorganizes taxation, provinces, administration, and court.
313	Constantine and Licinius agree on restoration and religious liberty, commonly called the Edict of Milan.
324-330	Constantine becomes sole emperor and dedicates Constantinople; a second Senate develops there.
380-381	Theodosius I supports Nicene Christianity and the Council of Constantinople.
395	Death of Theodosius I; permanent separate eastern and western courts under Arcadius and Honorius.
410	Visigoths under Alaric sack Rome.
439	Vandals take Carthage, depriving the West of a crucial tax and grain region.
455	Vandals sack Rome after Valentinian III's murder and Petronius Maximus' collapse.
468	Massive eastern-western expedition against Vandal Africa fails.
476	Odoacer deposes Romulus Augustulus; Julius Nepos remains recognized in Dalmatia until 480.
6th century	The Roman Senate continues under Odoacer and Ostrogothic kings; Justinian's wars transform Italy.
Early 7th century	The Senate at Rome disappears from surviving evidence amid war, plague, and urban contraction.
1453	Ottoman conquest of Constantinople ends the Eastern Roman imperial government.

CHAPTER 26

Appendix B: Magistracies and Political Offices

Functions, powers, and place in a senatorial career

Office	Role
Consul	Two elected annually in the Republic. Held imperium, convened Senate and assemblies, led armies, executed policy, and named the year. Under the Empire the office remained prestigious but terms shortened and strategic command belonged to the emperor.
Praetor	Held imperium below the consul. Presided over courts and could command armies or govern provinces. Their edicts helped develop Roman civil law.
Censor	Two elected roughly every five years for an eighteen-month task. Conducted census, classified citizens, reviewed the Senate and equestrian order, contracted revenues and works, and enforced standards of public dignity.
Tribune of the plebs	Ten annually by the late Republic. Sacrosanct, able to aid citizens, veto many acts, convene Senate and plebeian council, and propose legislation. Office restricted to plebeians.
Quaestor	Managed treasury, military, provincial, and administrative finances. In the late Republic, election normally brought Senate membership.
Aedile	Four annually in the mature Republic: two plebeian and two curule. Supervised markets, streets, grain, festivals, and public order. Games offered candidates costly visibility.
Dictator	A temporary emergency magistrate nominated under traditional procedure, usually for a specific task and conventionally up to six months. Sulla and Caesar transformed the office through long, constitution-making dictatorships.
Master of the horse	Deputy appointed by a dictator, possessing delegated imperium.
Interrex	A patrician senator serving for five-day intervals to arrange elections when no qualified magistrate remained.
Proconsul / propraetor	A former magistrate whose imperium was extended to govern a province or continue a military command.
Pontifex maximus	Chief member of the pontifical college. Augustus and later emperors made the office part of imperial religious authority until Christian rulers ceased using it.
Princeps senatus	The senator listed first by the censors, usually a senior former censor of great prestige. Not an emperor, though Augustus' title princeps evoked this tradition.
Praetorian prefect	Originally commander of the emperor's guard; later a powerful military, judicial, and administrative official. Usually equestrian, demonstrating alternatives to senatorial office.
Urban prefect	In the Empire, a senior senator responsible for order and jurisdiction in Rome; the office became one of the highest senatorial posts.
Magister militum	Late Roman "master of soldiers," often commanding major field armies. In the fifth-century West, figures such as Stilicho, Aetius, and Ricimer could overshadow emperors.

CHAPTER 27

Appendix C: The Voting Assemblies

Who attended, what they elected, and how votes were counted

Body	Function
Comitia centuriata	All eligible male citizens organized into centuries. Elected consuls, praetors, and censors; decided certain war and capital matters. Property structure and voting order favored wealthier units.
Comitia tributa	All eligible male citizens organized into thirty-five tribes. Elected quaestors and curule aediles and passed laws. Each tribe cast one vote regardless of population.
Concilium plebis	Plebeians organized by tribe, presided over by a tribune or plebeian aedile. Elected tribunes and plebeian aediles and passed plebiscites, binding on all citizens after 287 BCE.
Comitia curiata	An archaic assembly of thirty curiae. By the late Republic its political role was mainly formal and religious, including the lex curiata connected with imperium.
Contio	A public meeting for speeches and discussion, not a voting assembly. Magistrates and tribunes used contiones to explain proposals, attack rivals, and test public response.

The counting principle

Individuals voted inside their century or tribe. That unit then cast one collective vote. The final result was therefore a majority of voting units, not a direct total of every individual ballot.

CHAPTER 28

Appendix D: Glossary of Roman Political Terms

A compact guide to the language of office and authority

Term	Meaning
Auctoritas	Prestige, influence, and recognized standing. Augustus claimed superior auctoritas even when particular legal powers resembled those of colleagues.
Dignitas	Accumulated honor, rank, achievement, and claim to respect. Elite civil wars were often framed as defense of dignitas.
Imperium	Command authority held by consuls, praetors, dictators, and prorogued governors; included military and coercive jurisdiction within defined limits.
Potestas	The legally recognized power of an office. Every magistracy had potestas; imperium was a higher and more specific form.
Mos maiorum	“Custom of the ancestors,” the precedents and social expectations that regulated conduct beyond written law.
Senatus consultum	A formal resolution of the Senate, technically advice in the Republic and increasingly legislative under the Empire.
Senatus consultum ultimum	An emergency resolution urging magistrates to protect the state; its legal implications and use of lethal force were disputed.
Plebiscitum	A measure passed by the Plebeian Council; binding on all citizens after the lex Hortensia.
Princeps	“First” or “leading citizen.” Augustus used the term to frame monarchy as preeminence within the Republic.
Imperator	A victorious commander’s acclamation and later a central imperial title and name element.
Caesar	Julius Caesar’s family name, transformed into an imperial title for rulers and designated junior emperors.
Augustus	Honorific granted to Octavian in 27 BCE; later the senior imperial title. Feminine Augusta honored imperial women.
Tribunicia potestas	Tribunician power held by emperors, providing sacrosanctity, initiative, veto, and a way of numbering regnal years.
Proconsulare imperium	Proconsular command over provinces and armies. The emperor’s superior version provided the main legal basis of military supremacy.
Maiestas	The “majesty” or sovereign dignity of the Roman people and later the emperor; injury to it could be prosecuted as treason.
Damnatio memoriae	Modern term for official condemnation of memory through erasure of names, alteration of images, and annulment of honors. Application was never perfectly complete.
Fiscus	Imperial financial resources and treasury, distinct in principle from the senatorial aerarium but increasingly central to government.
Aerarium	The traditional public treasury associated with the Temple of Saturn and senatorial supervision.
Cursus honorum	The customary and legally regulated sequence of magistracies pursued by Roman aristocrats.
Nobilitas	The governing nobility, especially families with consular ancestors; included both patrician and plebeian houses.
Novus homo	A “new man,” especially the first in his family to reach the consulship.
Patronage	Reciprocal relationships of protection, recommendation, service, and honor linking powerful patrons with clients, communities, and dependents.
Federates / foederati	Groups serving Rome under treaty. In late antiquity the word covers

Term	Meaning
	varied arrangements and should not imply a single ethnic or legal model.
Tetrarchy	The college of two senior Augusti and two junior Caesars developed by Diocletian.
Principate	Modern term for early imperial monarchy presented through republican offices and the image of the princeps.
Dominate	Modern term for the more explicit late imperial monarchy. Useful but can exaggerate a sharp constitutional break.

Appendix E: Evaluating the Ancient Sources

Bias, genre, rumor, inscriptions, law, archaeology, and modern interpretation

No surviving ancient author offers a neutral transcript of Roman politics. Historians selected events to explain moral decline, divine providence, constitutional change, or the character of rulers. Biographers arranged anecdotes under categories such as generosity, cruelty, sex, and death. Panegyrists praised living emperors. Christian authors interpreted persecution and victory within salvation history. Pagan writers often blamed abandonment of traditional cult. Each genre supplies evidence and distortion at the same time.

- Tacitus is indispensable for the early Principate and senatorial culture, but his compressed irony and moral architecture shape every scene.
- Suetonius preserves documents and court traditions beside gossip. His topical biographies are not chronological administrative histories.
- Cassius Dio was a senator with long governmental experience, but his work survives unevenly and interprets earlier periods through imperial assumptions.
- The *Historia Augusta* contains real material, invention, anachronism, jokes, and fabricated documents. It must be checked against inscriptions, coins, papyri, and other narratives.
- Inscriptions preserve decrees, careers, building records, dedications, and official language, but usually present the public face desired by patrons and rulers.
- Coins are mass political objects announcing titles, victories, deities, family, and ideals. They document claims more reliably than actual achievement.
- Law codes preserve imperial responses and general rules. Repeated laws may indicate enforcement difficulty, not universal compliance.
- Archaeology tests literary claims through settlement, fortification, production, burial, environmental evidence, and material change, but material patterns rarely explain motives by themselves.

The most reliable interpretation compares different categories of evidence and distinguishes event from accusation. An emperor's building can be archaeologically secure even if the motives assigned by a hostile writer are speculative. A persecution can be documented without accepting every martyr legend. A senatorial author's contempt can reveal elite values even when the underlying anecdote is doubtful.

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SENATUS POPULUSQUE ROMANUS

*The Senate and People of Rome - a formula that outlived the Republic,
continued under emperors, and remains embedded in Rome's civic identity.*